INTO FARMIRE

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Book 4 of the WereRune Series

Chapter 1: The Thorns of Mystery

The sun filtered through the dense canopy of the Deep Woods, casting golden light over the sprawling city of Terramechus. To the untrained eye, the city seemed to grow naturally from the forest itself, an extension of its will. Massive trees with trunks as wide as towers formed the foundation of the city. Their roots wove into coarse dirt paths and natural bridges, while flowering vines and moss blanketed the bark in a riot of green.

High above, clusters of translucent domes perched like dewdrops among the branches, their sleek, fibrous surfaces catching the sunlight. These structures served as research facilities, communal spaces, or the private quarters of the Aetherdren who preferred the heights. Between the domes stretched woven bridges, suspended delicately but reinforced with innovative craftsmanship, forming a network that connected the city like veins of a living organism.

On the forest floor, the life of the city was no less vibrant. Aetherdren scholars moved gracefully between their tasks, their robes a blend of moss, vines, and fibers that seemed more grown than tailored. Many carried Mantle devices, compact tools that pulsed faintly with energy drawn from the atmosphere, their designs an elegant mix of functionality and artistry. While raw Mantle energy in

Terramechus wasn't as dense as in Wererune, the Aetherdren had mastered the art of refining its ambient traces into a stable energy source—powering their homes, laboratories, and the very tools they carried.

The air hummed with quiet activity, not from the magic itself, but from the gentle sounds of life in Terramechus. Conversations murmured softly between scholars, the rustle of leaves punctuated by footsteps on natural paths, and the occasional hum of a Mantle-powered device echoed faintly, a reminder of the Aetherdren's mastery of their craft.

Nymira Mosslight moved quickly through the central avenue, her boots kicking up small puffs of dirt and loose petals from the well-trodden paths. Her silver hair, streaked with moss-green strands, caught the sunlight filtering through the trees, but she paid little attention to the beauty around her. Her sharp amber eyes were fixed on the sealed transport case in her hands—a cylinder of woven bark and copper filament, humming faintly with the Mantle charge that kept its contents stable.

A routine delivery. Soil samples from the outer research stations, bound for the Luminaris archives. She had made this walk a hundred times.

"Courier Mosslight!" A young Aetherdren scholar jogged to match her pace, clutching a data tablet. His antlers were barely more than nubs—still growing in. "The samples from Station Twelve—are those the amended readings or the originals?"

“Amended,” Nymira said without slowing. “Doctor Veris ran them twice after the first batch showed contamination. She wants them cross-referenced with the Valenroot findings before anyone publishes.”

The scholar scribbled a note, nearly tripping over a root. “And the transport case—is it Precision sealed or Force sealed?”

Nymira glanced at him sideways. “What do you think?”

He hesitated, studying the faint copper lines on the case. “Precision?”

“Because?”

“Because… Force sealing would compress the samples and corrupt the readings?”

Nymira allowed the ghost of a smile. “You’re learning.” She handed him the case. “Archive wing, third shelf, next to the Grimroot findings. And don’t shake it.”

The scholar nodded eagerly and hurried off. Nymira watched him go, wiping her hands on her satchel strap. Routine. Predictable. Safe. She liked it that way.

That was before the summons arrived.

The messenger found her at the base of the Luminaris—the tallest and most ancient tree in Terramechus, its colossal trunk spiraling skyward, dwarfing everything around it. The bark shimmered faintly, preserved and enhanced through generations of careful tending. To the Aetherdren, Luminaris was more than a landmark—it was a symbol of their

philosophy: harmony between strength and precision.

The messenger was out of breath, his robes disheveled, and his expression told her everything she needed to know before he opened his mouth.

"The Council requests your presence. Immediately."

Nymira's stomach tightened. The Council didn't summon couriers for routine business. "What's this about?"

The messenger shook his head, already backing away. "They didn't say. Only that it's urgent."

She adjusted the strap of her satchel, feeling the familiar weight of the Mantle-powered tools within. Unlike some Aetherdren who kept their work purely theoretical, Nymira believed in being prepared. Her occupation as a Science Courier had taught her that even the most carefully planned transport could go wrong.

She had a talent for Artificial bending—the ability to manipulate and shape matter with a precision that far surpassed most. It made her an asset on dangerous expeditions, where her skills could stabilize volatile artifacts or defend against attackers. But right now, climbing the spiraling steps of the Luminaris, her talent felt very small against whatever was waiting for her at the top.

The Council Hall, grown directly into the base of Luminaris, was a marvel of Force Bending. The tree's inner structure had been hollowed and reshaped without compromising its integrity, its entrance framed by intricate carvings depicting the evolution of

Aetherdren society: the discovery of using Mantle energy, their first experiments with bending, and the dual disciplines that defined their civilization—Force and Precision.

Nymira paused for a moment to admire the carvings. One panel depicted an Aetherdren bending the ground itself, hands outstretched as the earth swirled upward into a sheltering wall. Force Bending: the art of manipulating raw matter through sheer will and understanding. Below it, another panel showed an Aetherdren delicately assembling an artifact, fingers glowing faintly as tiny fragments of crystal and metal aligned into a seamless device. Precision Bending: the art of manipulating small materials used for devices, requiring focus, knowledge, and unparalleled control. It was this discipline that had given rise to their most intricate creations—tools, weapons, and artifacts that partnered with magic to make unique effects.

Nymira's own skills leaned heavily toward Precision Bending. It was why the Council trusted her to oversee delicate transports. But even she couldn't ignore the growing unease about the implications of Dark Matter bending—a theory whispered about in research circles but never formally practiced. The risks were unthinkable.

The chamber's ceiling arched high overhead, resembling the inside of a blossoming flower. Thin vines hung from the edges, swaying gently. Crystals embedded above reflected sunlight into the space, illuminating it with a soft, natural glow. The room

was quiet, but not silent—faint creaks and groans echoed from the living tree, a reminder that even here, life was in constant motion.

At the center stood the Aetherdren Council, five figures seated in thrones carved directly into the roots of Luminaris. The thrones were simple, adorned only with faint tracings of leaves and spiraling patterns that symbolized balance and growth.

"Nymira Mosslight," said Councilor Vireas, the eldest among them. His voice carried the weight of centuries, low and measured. His antlers, wrapped in trailing vines, gave him a regal presence, as though he had grown from the very earth itself.

Nymira bowed her head slightly. "Councilor Vireas. I came as soon as I received your summons."

"You are aware of the situation?"

She hesitated. "I've heard nothing specific."

Vireas studied her for a moment, then spoke the words that ended her routine forever.

"The Codex of Thorns has been stolen."

A murmur rippled through the chamber. Nymira's breath caught. The Codex—the capsule of void-colored soil that had consumed the research wing for the past year. She had transported samples related to it twice, always under the strictest security protocols.

"How?" she asked.

"It was intercepted en route to Valenroot," Vireas said gravely. "The knowledge it contains is unparalleled. The soil's properties defy everything we know about matter—void of color, devoid of light, yet

it vibrates with frequencies identical to raw Dark Matter. The potential implications are staggering."

"Potentially catastrophic," another councilor interjected, amber eyes narrowing. "Force and Precision Bending are disciplines we have mastered because we understand the risks. But Dark Matter? That is no longer bending. It is playing with creation itself."

Nymira's jaw tightened. She had heard the rumors—about researchers who had attempted to replicate the soil's properties. The failures were often catastrophic, not simply unstable but outright destructive.

Another councilor, a woman with bright green veins glowing faintly beneath her skin, leaned forward. "The Codex may be more than soil. It contains information—an ancient process for bending Dark Matter into something stable. If this knowledge were to fall into the wrong hands..."

She didn't need to finish the thought.

"This is why the Codex was transported covertly," Vireas continued. "Its theft was no random act. Whoever took it knew its value. We have traced it to Farmire, the Werebeast nation."

Nymira's blood ran cold. Farmire. She had never been there, but its reputation was impossible to ignore.

Vireas sighed, the weight of his centuries showing briefly in his expression. "Nymira, we need you to retrieve the Codex and ensure its safe transport to Valenroot. Your skill with Precision Bending is

unmatched, and your knowledge of Mantle-based artifacts makes you uniquely suited for this task. If the Codex has been compromised, you are the only one capable of stabilizing it."

Nymira straightened, her resolve hardening. "I understand, Councilor."

"Your journey will not be without risk," Vireas said. "Farmire does not trust outsiders, and they have little patience for Spellcasters or Artificials. But we have arranged for a guide—someone with experience navigating their territory."

Before Nymira could ask who, the doors to the chamber groaned open.

A figure strode inside, his steps confident, his presence shifting the mood of the room instantly.

He was tall and broad-shouldered, his silver hair tousled as if the wind had tried and failed to tame it. Scars marked his face—a faint line across one cheek, another barely visible beneath his stubble—but they only seemed to sharpen his already striking features. His piercing blue eyes flicked first to the Council, then to Nymira, lingering just long enough to give her the impression she was being sized up.

His attire was practical yet weathered: leather armor reinforced with fur-lined pauldrons, worn from years of use but still durable. A faded tattoo spiraled down one muscular arm, its meaning obscured by age and scars. His presence was entirely at odds with the tranquil elegance of the chamber, as if he'd been carved from a rougher, more dangerous world.

“Apologies for being late,” he said, his voice carrying an easy charm that undercut the tension in the room. “The forest doesn’t exactly roll out a carpet for folks like me. Something about wolves and bad manners.”

Nymira’s eyes narrowed. “Aldric Ferenhowl,” she said flatly. “You’re the guide?”

“Nice to meet you too, Twig,” Aldric replied, flashing a grin. “Yes, I’m the guide. You must be the brains, and I hear we are to go to Farmire. Should be a grand time.”

“Yes, yes. Let’s continue,” said Vireas, his tone sharp enough to cut through Aldric’s banter. “Aldric Ferenhowl has been chosen for his expertise. He has navigated the Deep Woods many times, including Farmire’s borders, and is familiar with Werebeast territory.”

“Unconventional is one way to put it,” Nymira muttered under her breath.

Aldric caught the comment and smirked. “And here I was thinking Aetherdren were all about polite conversation. Guess science doesn’t leave much room for charm.”

Vireas pressed on, ignoring them both. “The Codex was last seen being transported through the Deep Woods. Our scouts have traced its trail to Farmire. We suspect the culprits are moving it deeper into their territory.”

“Farmire,” Aldric said with a shrug. “Charming place. Everyone hates everyone else, but hey, they hate outsiders even more. Should be a warm

welcome."

"You will accompany Nymira," Vireas said. "Her Precision Bending is critical to this mission. Aldric, your role is to ensure her safe passage and assist in locating the artifact. You have contacts in the region, and your knowledge of Farmire will be invaluable."

Nymira tilted her head, eyeing Aldric. "You've been to Farmire before?"

"Plenty of times," Aldric replied. "It's not as bad as the stories make it out to be. Well, unless you're bad at reading the room. Or weak. Or too chatty." He glanced at her with exaggerated concern. "You're not too chatty, are you?"

She rolled her eyes. "I'm sure your stellar diplomacy skills will carry us through just fine."

The conversation dissolved into logistics—maps, routes, contingency plans—but Nymira's mind was already spinning. How had the thieves found the Codex? Who had tipped them off? And why would anyone in Farmire want something as esoteric as the Codex of Thorns?

As they left the Council Hall and stepped into the open air, the familiar sights of Terramechus greeted her—the massive trees, the bioluminescent flora, the translucent domes high above. Normally, the sight brought her calm. Today, it felt distant, like a memory she couldn't quite reach.

Beside her, Aldric walked with the ease of someone who didn't care much for weighty thoughts. His movements were fluid, almost wolf-like, his silver hair catching the dappled sunlight filtering through

the canopy.

"You seem awfully casual about all this," Nymira said.

"It's not my first rodeo," Aldric replied. "Farmire's not as scary as everyone thinks. Sure, they'll sneer at you, maybe spit in your direction, but they won't kill you outright."

"That's comforting," Nymira said dryly.

He smirked. "Besides, you Aetherdren have a knack for overthinking. Plan, analyze, rehearse—sometimes you just need to relax and just do the thing."

Nymira narrowed her eyes at him. "And what exactly do you think I'm here for? Decoration?"

"Science," Aldric said, gesturing vaguely at her with one hand. "You're the brains. I'm the brawn, remember? It's a good system."

Her lips pressed into a thin line. "If this is your idea of brawn, I can see why the Werebeasts don't like you."

That earned her a sharp, wolfish grin. "Don't worry, Twig. I've got just enough charm to keep us alive. And if not, well..." He flexed his fingers, cracking his knuckles. "Let's just say I've got backup plans."

Nymira sighed, already regretting her new traveling companion. As the two of them descended the winding paths of Terramechus, the city gradually faded behind them, swallowed by the vast expanse of the Deep Woods.

Ahead lay Farmire—a land of danger, hostility, and ancient tensions that the Aetherdren had spent centuries pretending didn't concern them. Behind them, the safety of Terramechus grew more distant with every step, and with it, everything Nymira had thought she understood about the world beyond the trees.

She was a Science Courier. She delivered samples and stabilized artifacts. She was not a soldier, not an adventurer, and certainly not the kind of person who walked into hostile territory with a Werewolf she'd met an hour ago. And yet, here she was. Because sometimes being the right person for the job meant being the only person for the job.

“Let’s just get this over with,” Nymira muttered, adjusting the strap of her satchel.

“Cheer up, Twig,” Aldric said, glancing over his shoulder. “It’s going to be an adventure.”

Nymira didn’t respond. She was too busy wondering whether she’d make it out alive.

Chapter 2: Into the Deep Woods

Leaving Terramechus wasn't as simple as walking out of a city gate. The transition felt sharper, more deliberate. One moment, the air hummed softly with the presence of Mantle-powered tools, glowing flora, and the gentle murmur of Aetherdren life. The next, the comfort of civilization faded into the looming quiet of the Deep Woods.

The trees here weren't the carefully cultivated giants of Terramechus, with their bioluminescent leaves and carefully grown walkways. These were old and chaotic—twisted trunks wrapped in vines, roots sprawling across the dirt like tangled veins, and branches so thick they blocked out the sky entirely in places. The sunlight barely broke through the dense canopy, leaving everything in a dim, greenish haze.

The sounds were different too. In Terramechus, the forest hummed with engineered harmony—the soft glow of Mantle devices, the murmur of scholars, the creak of well-maintained bridges. Here, the Deep Woods groaned. The trees shifted and settled like sleeping giants, their ancient wood popping and cracking in the humid air. Strange calls echoed from somewhere far above—birds, maybe, or something that only pretended to be birds. And beneath it all, a constant, low vibration that Nymira could feel in her teeth, as though the forest itself had a heartbeat.

Nymira adjusted the strap of her satchel, keeping her focus on the path ahead. She wasn't afraid of the Deep Woods—not exactly. But she knew enough to stay wary. The Deep Woods didn't play by the same rules as the rest of the world.

Behind her, Aldric moved with an ease that grated on her nerves. He carried himself like someone who didn't care about the shadows, the overgrown roots, or the distant rustle of something unseen. His silver hair caught the occasional stray beam of light, and his leather armor looked as though it had seen better days.

"Relax," Aldric said, as if sensing her unease. He pushed a low-hanging branch out of the way and let it snap back, forcing Nymira to duck with an irritated huff. "The Deep Woods aren't so bad once you accept they're always trying to kill you. Keeps things interesting."

"Easy for you to say," Nymira shot back, sidestepping a gnarled root that had tripped her twice already. "You've been stomping around these woods your entire life. I'm not exactly used to places where Hollowborn could pop out of every shadow."

"They won't pop out of every shadow," Aldric said with a teasing grin. "Just most of them. It's not personal—they'd eat me too if they got the chance."

Nymira muttered something under her breath and kept walking, but Aldric wasn't done. "You know," he said casually, "if we do run into trouble, you should probably leave the fighting to me. Swords and claws are better for combat than... whatever it is you

Artificials do."

He ended the sentence there, letting it hang in the air just long enough to set up whatever response he knew was coming.

After a moment of silence, Nymira spoke up. "Do you even know what an Artificial is? Or how much training it takes to become one?"

Aldric raised an eyebrow, his tone casual. "Sure. You bend stuff, right? Like wood and rocks. Sounds useful. Saves on nails."

Nymira stopped mid-step, turning to glare at him. "It's not about 'saving on nails.' It's about understanding matter. An Artificial doesn't just wave their hands and hope for the best like a spellcaster. We study every detail—structure, density, composition. When we bend something, we reshape it with precision. It's science, not guesswork."

Aldric smirked. "Sounds rather boring. Keep it simple, just swing at things until they break."

"And that," Nymira said, her voice clipped, "is exactly why I'm here."

Aldric chuckled, but his grin sharpened. "Alright, Professor. If it's so impressive, why don't you prove it?"

"Prove it?" she echoed, her amber eyes narrowing.

"Yeah," Aldric said, gesturing lazily toward a nearby tree. "Do something cool. Bend something, use an artifact. You know, something flashy that makes us simple folk go 'ooh' and 'ahh.'"

Nymira hesitated for a fraction of a second, her professional demeanor warring with the thrill of a

challenge. She straightened her posture, brushing a loose strand of silver hair out of her face. “Fine. Observe.”

She dropped her satchel to the ground with deliberate care, pulling out a small artifact—about the size of a plum. The sphere gleamed faintly, its surface etched with intricate patterns that seemed to ripple under the light. She held it up, letting Aldric get a good look before shifting her focus to the tree he’d pointed out.

Aiming her free hand towards the tree, Nymira closed her eyes for a moment, inhaling deeply. When she exhaled, the bark on the tree rippled, twisting like a living thing. Thin tendrils of wood spiraled outward, forming a jagged hollow in the tree. She pulled her hand back, and the bark settled into its new shape like it had always been that way.

Aldric let out a low whistle. “Not bad. Still just a fancy way of whittling, though.”

“Oh, I’m not done yet,” Nymira said, a sly smile creeping across her lips.

She tossed the artifact into the hollow she’d just molded. Then with a snap of her fingers, the air around the artifact shimmered.Then the artifact detonated with a sharp crack, splintering the bark in a controlled burst of light and sound.

“Happy now?” Nymira asked, dusting her hands off and retrieving her satchel.

Aldric blinked, then let out a low chuckle. “Not bad, Twig. For all that drama, you actually know what you’re doing. Guess I’ll stop worrying about you

blowing us up by mistake."

Nymira gave him a sharp look, but there was no real malice behind it. "How generous of you."

"Hey, credit where it's due," Aldric said with a grin, falling back into his easy stride. "I mean, if all Artificials were this good, maybe I wouldn't keep saying swords are better. You've got style, though. Gotta give you that."

Nymira blinked at him, caught off guard by the hint of sincerity in his tone. The corner of her lips twitched upward despite herself. "Well, if that's the closest thing to a compliment I'm going to get, I'll take it."

Aldric stopped in his tracks, turning to face her with an exaggerated flourish. He swept into a low, cocky bow, one arm crossed over his chest while the other gestured grandly.

But then.

The air changed suddenly, and Nymira felt it immediately. It was subtle at first—a faint metallic tang on her tongue, the kind of sensation that came with a storm or a Mantle trench. But this wasn't natural.

"Do you feel that?" she asked, her voice low.

Aldric nodded, his hand moving instinctively to the hilt of his sword. "About to have a little fun are we?"

They barely had time to react before the first Hollowborn appeared. It came from the shadows, a twisted mockery of life that moved with an unnatural grace.

The creature had once been an Aetherdren, its elongated limbs and bark-like skin still recognizable despite the corruption. Its hollow eyes glowed faintly with a sickly purple light, and its movements were jerky, as if it was being controlled by invisible strings.

“Hollowborn,” Nymira whispered, already pulling another artifact from her satchel.

“Stay close,” Aldric said, drawing his sword.

The Hollowborn Aetherdren wasn’t alone. Another figure emerged from the trees—a grotesque Wereraven with skeletal wings and clawed hands. Its body was covered in tattered feathers, and its glowing red eyes locked onto them with a predatory hunger.

The Wereraven screeched, and both creatures charged.

Aldric met the Aetherdren head-on, his sword clashing against the creature’s jagged claws. He moved with precision, every strike aimed to cripple. The Hollowborn’s attacks were erratic, wild—but strong. One swipe caught Aldric’s shoulder guard, tearing the leather and sending him stumbling back a step. He recovered fast, rolling under the next swing and driving his blade into the creature’s side.

The thing barely flinched. It wrenched itself free of the sword and lunged again, its hollow eyes burning brighter.

"These things don’t stay down easy!" Aldric shouted, parrying a clawed hand that cracked against his blade hard enough to send sparks flying.

He ducked another wild swipe, felt the rush of air as corrupted fingers missed his throat by inches. The

Hollowborn was relentless—no pain, no hesitation, just a mindless fury that kept coming. Aldric planted his feet, feinted left, then drove his sword upward through the creature's chest. It staggered, claws raking uselessly at the blade, but still didn't fall.

"Any time now would be great, Twig!" he called through gritted teeth, twisting the sword and ripping it free.

Meanwhile, the Wereraven dove at Nymira from above. She threw an explosive artifact into the air, bending the frequencies around it to trigger the detonation. The burst pushed the creature back, but it recovered faster than she expected—twisting mid-air and launching itself at her again, talons extended.

Nymira dropped flat, feeling the rush of wind as the creature passed inches above her. Her heart hammered. She rolled to her knees and reached out with both hands, bending the surrounding bark into sharp tendrils.

The tendrils shot forward, impaling the Wereraven and pinning it to a nearby tree. It writhed and screeched, thrashing against the wooden spears. One tendril snapped. Then another.

"Hold, hold—" Nymira whispered through gritted teeth, pouring everything she had into keeping the creature pinned. Sweat beaded on her forehead. The bark groaned under the strain.

The Wereraven's talons slashed through a third tendril, and for a terrible moment she thought it would break free. She reached deeper, bending not just the bark but the wood beneath it—denser,

stronger. New tendrils erupted from the trunk, thicker than the first, piercing the creature from multiple angles. It let out one final, hollow screech before shuddering, cracking, and disintegrating into ash.

Nymira gasped, her arms trembling from the effort.

Behind her, Aldric's fight had turned brutal. The corrupted Aetherdren had backed him against a tree, its claws raking against his blade in a flurry of strikes. Aldric ducked a swing that gouged a chunk from the trunk behind him, then drove his sword upward through the creature's jaw. It convulsed, then collapsed into corrupted wood and moss before crumbling into ash.

He stood there, chest heaving, blood running from a shallow cut on his forearm.

"Not bad," he said, wiping his blade on the grass.

"You too," Nymira replied, though her hands still trembled faintly as she tucked the artifact back into her satchel. After a moment, she asked, "Curious, why didn't you transform?"

Aldric hesitated, his hand lingering on the hilt of his sword as he sheathed it. For a moment, he didn't answer, his usual confidence replaced with something quieter.

"Well—" Aldric's voice hitched slightly before he cleared his throat. His gaze drifted somewhere over Nymira's shoulder, avoiding her eyes. "Werewolves... it's not as simple as you'd think."

Nymira tilted her head, curiosity sharpening her expression. “Not simple how?”

He hesitated, his hand resting on the hilt of his sword like it was an anchor. “We take pride in staying… tamed. Shifting isn’t just about the claws or the teeth. It’s—” He stopped himself, the words catching. After a moment, he exhaled, his shoulders tightening. “It’s about control. You start giving in, it gets harder to stop. Harder to come back.”

The air between them seemed to grow heavier. Nymira studied him, the question on her lips unspoken but lingering. There was something raw in his voice, just beneath the surface, and the way his hand flexed slightly against the hilt of his blade told her not to push.

Instead, she adjusted the strap of her satchel and nodded. “That makes sense.” Her voice was softer than usual, almost careful.

Aldric’s lips twitched into a grin, though it didn’t reach his eyes at first. “Don’t go turning this into a heartfelt moment, Twig,” he said, his tone sliding back into its usual cocky ease. “I’ve got a reputation to maintain.”

Nymira rolled her eyes but let the moment pass. “Let’s keep moving,” she said, taking the lead.

As Aldric followed, he allowed his grin to widen, the tension in his frame easing just enough. But his gaze lingered on the path ahead, as though he were seeing something much farther away.

By the time they reached Featherfall, the forest was alive with shadows and glimmers of faint light

from high above. The treetop village sprawled like an intricate web, with platforms, bridges, and ropes connecting the heights. Below, on the forest floor, the lower-class Wereravens toiled and lived in simple, crude huts, their surroundings dim and damp compared to the lofty perches of their superiors.

Aldric's steps slowed as they approached a group of Wereraven guards stationed near the base of a massive tree. Their leather-and-feather armor gleamed faintly, and their sharp beaks and glowing crimson eyes gave them an imposing air.

The lead guard, a tall and lean figure with a sleek hood of feathers framing his face, tilted his head as they approached. His black talons clicked against the hilt of a curved dagger. "Well," the Wereraven drawled in a tone laced with mockery, "what have we here? A Werewolf and an Aetherdren. Strange company for this part of the woods."

"We've got business," Aldric said, his grin easy and unbothered. "Important stuff."

The guard crossed his arms, the faint shimmer of amusement in his eyes suggesting he wasn't buying it. "Yeah, sure. Look, I don't know if you really have business here—"

Before he could finish, Aldric raised his voice, pointing to a nearby Wereraven who was minding his own business at the edge of the clearing. "Hey, Clomire!"

The Wereraven, caught off guard, turned his sharp eyes toward Aldric. He tilted his head, his expression unreadable.

“Remember me?” Aldric said, striding toward him and gesturing as if they were old friends. “You helped me out a while back. Think you can do it again?”

The Wereraven blinked slowly, his crimson gaze traveling up and down Aldric’s frame. After a beat, he responded in a calm, measured tone, “Yeah, that’s my friend. Think you guys can let him through? He won’t be any trouble, promise.”

“You know- him?” The guard confused looking at Aldric who was grinning.

“Yes we go way back, an old courier buddy.” The composed Wereraven responded.

The lead guard frowned, visibly thrown off by the exchange but unwilling to escalate. “Eh, whatever,” he said with a dismissive wave. “With all the Hollowborn crawling around lately, I don’t feel like dealing with this. Whatever you’ve got to do here, make it quick.”

Aldric nodded, his grin widening. “As quick as a Wereleopard. Got it.” He turned to Nymira. “Shall we?”

Nymira, still puzzled by the exchange, followed Aldric as they passed through the guards. They quickly caught up to Wereraven friend, who was leaning against a low-hanging branch with an air of casual indifference.

“Thanks for the help,” Aldric said, pulling out a small pouch of Werebeast currency and discreetly slipping it into the Wereravens hand.

His talons closed around the pouch, and he gave a slight nod. “Pleasure doing business.”

“Hey,” Aldric said, his tone still light, “Do you know where I can find Korva Nightkeeper?”

Clomire clicked his beak thoughtfully. “Korva, huh? Doesn’t ring a bell.”

Without missing a beat, Aldric reached into his pocket and produced another pouch of currency, pressing it into the Wereravens hand with a knowing look.

The Wereravens eyes glinted with amusement as he weighed the pouch in his palm. “Oh, yeah, now I remember. Ask the bartender at Clipped Taverns. He should help… might not.”

Aldric smirked, unfazed by the warning. “Thank you, friend. We’ll let you get back to it.”

As the Wereraven disappeared into the shadows, Nymira turned to Aldric, her brow furrowed. “You didn’t really know him, did you?”

Aldric’s grin was pure mischief. “Well of course not, its part of the game, Twig. You’ll learn.”

Chapter 3: The Bet

The climb up through Featherfall was more than a little eye-opening for Nymira. The lower levels, clustered close to the ground, had been rough and chaotic—haphazard shelters slapped together with what looked like desperation and very little planning. Mud clung to every surface, and the air smelled faintly of decay and damp feathers. But as they ascended into the treetop city, things began to change.

The structures became sturdier, their walls formed of carefully carved wood and reinforced with iron bands. Rope bridges gave way to proper wooden planks, and the flicker of torchlight was replaced by glowing orbs of faint, amber light. The chatter of Wereravens grew less frenzied and more measured. The higher they climbed, the more the village resembled a true society rather than a loose collection of outcasts.

"See?" Aldric said, gesturing at the polished railings of a well-maintained walkway. "Not all birds live in nests made of mud and spit."

Nymira wrinkled her nose. "I wasn't going to say that."

"Yeah but you were probably thinking it."

She sighed but didn't argue. Instead, her attention drifted to the conversations around them. The Wereravens in the upper tiers were speaking in hushed tones, but the snippets she caught all seemed

to circle back to the same topics: Hollowborn attacks increasing near the borders, whispers of the Pale Weaver returning, and the Tombstone Order's alleged involvement.

Nymira frowned, her boots crunching softly on the uneven ground. "Do they really think the Tombstone Order has something to do with the Pale Weaver?"

Aldric shrugged, adjusting his sword strap casually. "The Tombstone deals with Hollowborn, right? People see more Hollowborn popping up, they get spooked and start connecting dots that aren't there. Doesn't have to make sense—it just has to spread."

Nymira's brow furrowed further as she mulled it over. "But the Pale Weaver is just… a myth. Stories to explain things people couldn't back then. There's no actual evidence she ever existed."

Aldric gave a low chuckle, the kind that usually preceded him saying something annoyingly smug. "Sure, Twig. And myths have never caused any real-world problems before, huh? Ever heard of people starting wars over stories?"

She shot him a sharp look but didn't rise to the bait. "You're deflecting. What I mean is, just because people believe in her doesn't make it real."

"Doesn't make it fake either," Aldric countered, his tone light but with an edge of curiosity. "You Aetherdren are supposed to be all about keeping an open mind, aren't you?"

Nymira hesitated, her fingers brushing against the strap of her satchel. She took a measured breath before replying, her voice more subdued. “The Codex’s soil. The research says it’s from a Dead Garden. If that’s true…”

She trailed off, and Aldric glanced over at her, one brow raised. “Go on. If it’s true, then what?”

“Then maybe,” Nymira said slowly, “the Pale Weaver isn’t just a myth. But even if the soil is from a Dead Garden, that doesn’t mean the rest of the stories are true. An Aetherdren capable of existing in multiple places at once, summoning Hollowborn at will, and teleporting across dimensions? No, no… It’s improbable at best.”

Aldric smirked. “Improbable, sure. But not impossible.”

Nymira rolled her eyes. “The soil is fascinating, yes. But it’s still just soil with anomalous properties. It’s no reason to start believing every half-baked story about the Pale Weaver wandering around creating chaos.”

Aldric tilted his head, a sly grin spreading across his face. “You know, for someone so obsessed with figuring out the unknown, you sound awfully resistant to the idea of this particular unknown being true.”

“It’s not resistance,” Nymira said, her voice clipped. “It’s rational skepticism. That’s what keeps science grounded.”

“Grounded. Right,” Aldric said, his grin unwavering. “Well, while you’re grounding yourself in skepticism, maybe don’t ignore the fact that your little

Codex has caused a lot of trouble for something that's 'just soil.'"

Nymira opened her mouth to retort but froze as their destination came into view.

The Clipped Tavern loomed ahead, its polished wood glinting faintly in the light of magic-powered lanterns. The structure was startlingly refined compared to its surroundings—elegant carvings lined the walls, and gleaming metal accents gave it an air of sophistication. Ivy crept artfully up its sides, and the warm glow from the lanterns made the place seem both inviting and strangely out of place amidst the rough-hewn world of the Wereravens.

"This is... unexpected," Nymira admitted as they approached the entrance.

"Yeah," Aldric said, tilting his head. "I was expecting something more... splintery."

Nymira squinted at one of the magic lanterns, watching the soft glow pulse within the glass casing. "Artificial bending just to make electricity. What a waste of Mantle energy."

A few nearby Wereravens shot her sharp glances, their eyes darkening. Oblivious, Nymira kept going. "Why not just bend some Glowvine? They're natural, efficient, and—"

Aldric coughed loudly. "Twig."

She turned to him, confused—until she caught the way the room had gone uncomfortably still. The realization hit her like a stone to the head: Werebeasts couldn't use magic or bend matter.

“Right,” she muttered, suddenly fascinated with the floor. “Sorry.”

Aldric gave the bartender a lopsided grin, smoothing over the moment. “Gotta admit, though, those lanterns must’ve cost a fortune. Getting them all the way from Wererune? That’s a rare bit of luxury.”

The bartender, a tall Wereraven with sleek black feathers and a worn leather apron, narrowed his crimson eyes. He didn’t respond, his expression unmoved by Aldric’s attempt at charm.

Unfazed, Aldric leaned an elbow on the counter, lowering his voice just enough to sound casual. “We’re looking for someone. Word is, Korva Nightkeeper is spending her nights here.”

The bartender didn’t reply immediately. Instead, he tilted his head, eyeing Aldric like he was sizing up prey. “What’s it worth to you?”

Aldric reached into his pocket and placed a few coins of Werebeast currency on the counter. The bartender snorted.

“Nice try, wolf. That barely covers the time it took me to listen to you.”

Before Aldric could respond, Nymira calmly pulled a small artifact from her satchel—a slender carving tool, its surface etched with precise lines of Mantle-energy conduits. She placed it on the counter with an air of authority, her expression neutral but her tone brimming with confidence.

“How about this?” she said smoothly. “A Mantle-powered blade that focuses raw energy into the sharpest edge imaginable. Precision work beyond

anything steel could ever achieve. Easily worth three times what he just offered.”

The bartender’s gaze flicked to the artifact, his keen eyes narrowing as he assessed it. For a tense moment, the only sound was the hum of Mantle energy faintly vibrating from the blade. Finally, he gave a curt nod. “Alright. Back room.”

As they followed him, Aldric leaned in close to Nymira, a grin tugging at his lips. “Nice move, Twig. Overhyping a glorified carving tool? You’re catching on.”

Nymira’s professional facade didn’t falter, but there was a glimmer of satisfaction in her eyes as she adjusted her satchel.

The back room was cramped and dim, lit by a single lantern that cast long shadows across stacked crates and barrels. Sitting on one of the crates, legs crossed, a curved dagger balanced on her knee, was Korva Nightkeeper.

She was lean and sharp—everything about her seemed designed for speed and lethality. Her feathers were darker than most Wereravens, almost blue-black, and her crimson eyes held the calculating stillness of someone who had learned long ago that trust was a luxury. Scars ran along the edges of her wings—old wounds, earned and kept like trophies.

She didn’t look up from the dagger. The blade spun lazily on her fingertip, catching the light.

"Aldric," she said. "You still owe me for the last time."

"Which is why I brought payment and a business opportunity." He dropped a heavy pouch on the crate beside her. "We need to get into Tinmaal."

Korva's eyes flicked to Nymira, then back to Aldric. The dagger stopped spinning. "Tinmaal. As in Krugen Maar's Tinmaal."

"That's the one."

"You're insane."

"I've been told."

Korva studied Nymira openly, her gaze traveling from the satchel to the bark-textured skin, the moss-green streaks in her hair. "An Aetherdren. In Farmire." She looked at Aldric. "You're bringing a tree into lion territory."

"She's useful," Aldric said simply.

"I'm standing right here," Nymira said.

Korva's beak-like features curved into something between a smirk and a sneer. "Can she fight?"

"She can bend stone, shape metal, and detonate explosives from a distance."

"That wasn't what I asked."

Aldric met her gaze steadily. "She held her own against two Hollowborn on the way here. One of them was a corrupted Wereraven."

Something flickered in Korva's crimson eyes—not quite respect, but an acknowledgment. She turned to Nymira. "You killed one of my kind? A Hollowborn one, sure, but still."

Nymira's jaw tightened. "I did what I had to."

Korva held her gaze for a long moment. Then she let out a short, sharp laugh. "Good. You might

actually survive this."

She slid off the crate, sheathing her dagger in one fluid motion. "Here's my terms—I get you in and I get you to the door. After that, I'm out. And I keep whatever I find along the way."

"Done," Aldric said.

Nymira frowned. "Just like that? No negotiation?"

"Korva doesn't negotiate, Twig. She sets terms. You take them or you leave."

Korva moved to the door. "We leave at dusk. The approach through the lower woods takes half a day. I know a route that avoids the outer patrols."

She paused, glancing back at Nymira. "One more thing. In Tinmaal, the lionesses fight and the males craft. Don't let their size fool you—the women are faster than they look, and the men can hear a pin drop from across a hall. Keep your bending subtle or don't bend at all."

Then she was gone, slipping through the tavern crowd like smoke.

Nymira stared after her, then turned to Aldric. "You trust her?"

Aldric considered the question—actually considered it, which was unusual for him. "I trust that she wants to get paid. And I trust that she's smart enough to know that getting us killed means she doesn't get paid. Beyond that?" He shrugged. "She's the best at what she does. And out here, that's what matters."

Nymira wasn't entirely reassured, but she had no better options. She adjusted her satchel, feeling the

weight of the tools inside—the artifacts, the bending gloves, the emergency supplies she'd packed back in Terramechus when this had still been a simple retrieval mission.

It felt like a lifetime ago.

"How long until dusk?" she asked.

"Few hours," Aldric said, settling onto a crate with the practiced ease of someone who could sleep anywhere. "I'd suggest getting some rest, but something tells me you're not great at relaxing."

"I'm a scientist. We don't relax. We prepare."

"Same thing, just less fun." He crossed his arms and closed his eyes. "Wake me when it's time to go, Twig."

Nymira sat across from him, pulling a small notebook from her satchel. She began sketching notes about everything she'd observed since entering Farmire—the Hollowborn, the Wereraven social structure, the Tombstone water rumors. If she made it home, this would be the most comprehensive field study of Farmire any Aetherdren had ever produced.

If she made it home.

Chapter 4: Into the Lion's Den

The air in Tinmaal was thick with tension, the kind that clung to the skin and made every breath feel weighted. The reddish-orange haze filtering through the treetop canopy bathed the entire settlement in an otherworldly glow, casting jagged shadows over the massive stone structures below. Every sound—the bark of gravelly voices, the rhythmic clang of metal striking metal, and the low rumble of warriors sparring—painted a picture of life that was equal parts disciplined and volatile.

Nymira crouched low behind a crumbling stone wall, her amber eyes fixed on a pair of Werelion guards strolling through the haze. Both were women—tall, broad-shouldered, and exuding a quiet ferocity. Their golden eyes scanned their surroundings like predators searching for prey, and the axes slung over their shoulders gleamed with sharp precision, clearly well-maintained. Even at rest, they moved with a coiled readiness that spoke of years of training—or perhaps something more instinctual, bred into them over generations of warfare.

"Why are all the warriors female?" Nymira whispered, glancing at Korva, who lingered in the shadows beside her.

Korva's crimson eyes flicked toward the guards, her expression neutral but knowing. "That's the way

of the Werelions. The lionesses fight, hunt, and kill. And they take pride in it." Her voice dropped a touch lower, her tone sharpening. "They're vicious and efficient. Krugen Maar may lead, but it's the lionesses you should fear."

Aldric, crouched on Nymira's other side, tilted his head slightly as he studied the guards. "Guess that leaves the men to bark orders and keep their claws clean?"

"Not quite," Korva replied smoothly, a faint smirk tugging at her beak-like features. "The males handle crafting, building, even cooking. They plan, they command. And don't let the lack of weapons fool you. They have their own kind of pride—literal and figurative." She gestured subtly toward the base of a nearby stone column, where intricate carvings depicted scenes of battle, hunting, and community. Each detail was immaculate, from the fierce snarl of a lioness mid-charge to the gentle curve of a cub cradled in its mother's arms. "Their hands don't just make weapons—they make art."

Nymira's gaze lingered on the carvings for a moment. "I'll give them that. Their craftsmanship is… impressive."

Aldric smirked. "Impressive enough to distract you from the fact that those lionesses would happily tear you in half?"

Nymira shot him a glare. "Thanks for the reminder."

"Anytime," he replied, his grin widening.

The two guards passed by, their heads held high. Even in their movements—measured, deliberate, with the faintest hint of swagger—Nymira could see they knew their worth. These weren't warriors conscripted out of necessity; they were hunters who loved the thrill of the fight, who relished their role within the pride.

As the guards disappeared around the corner, their faint voices blending into the distant din of Tinmaal, Nymira turned to Korva, her tone curious but skeptical. "Earlier, you mentioned the Tombstone ritual water. Is it really worth all this trouble? Or is it just another Deep Woods fairy tale?"

Korva's crimson eyes glinted faintly in the haze as she shifted her weight, her voice calm and measured. "That depends. If you're the kind to value knowledge, the Codex holds more promise. Priceless to the right buyer—if they can even comprehend what's in it. But the water? That's different. It's... well, it's the kind of power people would burn the world down for."

"Power and green spooky eyes," Aldric quipped, his grin as casual as his tone.

Korva's feathers ruffled slightly, and she fixed him with a dry look. "Yes, the eyes are a 'side effect' of the Tombstone Order. But the water isn't about aesthetics. Supposedly, it transforms the drinker—makes them stronger, faster. A living weapon."

Nymira frowned, leaning in slightly. "So what's the catch? Nothing comes without one."

Korva tilted her head, her expression sharp with thought. “It’s intent. That’s what they say, anyway. The water… doesn’t take kindly to greed or ambition. If your reasons for drinking it aren’t pure, it doesn’t just change you—it ruins you.”

“Ruins you how?” Nymira asked, her brows furrowing.

“They call them Stoneborn,” Korva said, lowering her voice slightly. “Twisted, corrupted versions of the Tombstone warriors. Stronger, faster, but… hollow. They lose their grip on reality, becoming little more than violent, reckless animals. The stories claim the Tombstone Order made it that way on purpose—some kind of built-in punishment for those who’d misuse their power.”

“Stoneborn…” Nymira whispered, her voice barely audible. She folded her arms, her gaze flicking toward the towering structures of Tinmaal. “And this is all just… mythology? Superstition?”

Korva gave a faint shrug. “That depends on who you ask. To some, it’s fact. To others, it’s a convenient tale to keep people in line.” She glanced at Aldric. “And what about you, wolf? Do the stories match what you’ve seen out in Wererune?”

Aldric scratched the back of his neck, his expression unreadable for a moment. “The Tombstone Order’s still going strong out there, so… who knows? I’ve heard enough stories to fill a book, but I’ve never seen anyone down a vial of the stuff. Doesn’t mean it’s not true, though.”

Nymira studied him, her voice tinged with curiosity. “And you believe it?”

Aldric smirked, though there was a flicker of something more serious in his eyes. “I believe that some stories are there for a reason. Might be truth, might be a warning. Either way, it’s not worth testing.”

Korva let out a quiet huff of amusement. “A rare moment of wisdom from you, Aldric.”

“Don’t get used to it,” he shot back, his grin returning.

Nymira glanced at the two of them, her mind turning over the implications. The Tombstone water, the Stoneborn, the Codex of Thorns—it all felt too surreal, like pieces of a puzzle she wasn’t sure she wanted to solve…

She shook the thought away, focusing on the task at hand. “So, what’s the plan now?”

Korva adjusted the strap on her shoulder, her tone turning practical. “I’m sticking to the trees and shadows from here. Alone.”

Nymira blinked. “Alone? Why?”

Korva’s crimson gaze flicked to her, sharp and unapologetic. “No offense, but I’m not risking getting caught because of you two. Our deal doesn’t include me dying in Tinmaal.”

Aldric chuckled under his breath. “Fair enough I suppose.”

Korva gave him a curt nod, her crimson eyes gleaming faintly in the haze. “I’ll meet you at the side entrance. And don't get caught.”

Before either of them could respond, she disappeared into the shadows, her movements so swift and silent it was as though she'd melted into the landscape itself.

Nymira watched her go, an uneasy feeling settling in her chest. "I don't like this."

Aldric adjusted the strap of his sword and flashed her a confident grin. "Relax, Twig. We've made it this far. What's the worst that could happen?"

She shot him a glare, but it was half-hearted. "You really don't believe in jinxing yourself, do you?"

"Not at all," he said, gesturing for her to follow. "Come on. Let's not keep her waiting."

As they crept forward through the oppressive haze of Tinmaal, the weight of the rumors and stories pressed heavier on Nymira's mind.

Nymira and Aldric crept along the edges of the settlement, their movements synchronized as they avoided the glow of firelight. The reddish-orange haze of Tinmaal created deep, sharp shadows that painted the stone walls and tents. They ducked behind a low wooden barrier, holding their breath as three lionesses sauntered into view.

The lionesses stood tall, their golden fur shimmering in the firelight. Their toned frames were adorned with leather armor, and their piercing eyes radiate confidence. One of them laughed, her voice rich and mocking. "Did you see those Werecrows the other day? They call themselves 'warriors from the shadows'? Please, they're nothing but scavengers."

Another snorted. “The Werebears aren’t any better. All muscle, no brains. Pfft, typical.”

The third one’s sneer widened. “And the Aetherdren are the opposite, All brains. One warrior could crush all those pompous spriggans.”

Nymira bristled, her jaw tightening and making a fist. She shifted slightly, her boot brushing against a loose twig, which snapped underfoot. The sound carried just enough to make one of the lionesses pause.

Aldric acted instantly, scooping up a small rock and chucking it toward an iron cauldron a few feet away. The clang of the rock striking metal echoed, drawing the lionesses’ attention.

“What was that?” one asked, gripping her spear.

“Probably a squirrel,” another growled, stalking toward the noise. “Maybe we can throw it in?”

Aldric tugged Nymira’s sleeve. “Come on,” he whispered. They slipped past unnoticed, hearts racing.

Ahead, the sound of footsteps grew heavier. A towering figure emerged from the shadows—a lioness clad in heavy, intricately carved bronze armor. Her long, dreaded mane flowed over her shoulders, glinting faintly in the dim light. She carried a spear with practiced ease, her sharp eyes scanning her surroundings.

Nymira nudged Aldric, her voice barely audible. “She’s enormous.”

“Still beautiful, though,” Aldric murmured with a smirk.

The lioness paused for a moment, her spear resting against her shoulder as she adjusted her gauntlets. Nymira and Aldric dove into a pile of hay nearby, pressing themselves flat and holding their breath.

The lioness's ears twitched. She turned her head slowly, nostrils flaring, golden eyes scanning the exact spot where they'd been standing moments before. Time stretched. Nymira could feel the vibration of each heavy footfall through the ground beneath her. Hay prickled against her skin, and she clamped her jaw shut to stop from sneezing.

One step closer. The lioness's shadow fell across the hay pile. Her spear lowered slightly.

Then, from somewhere deeper in the settlement, a horn sounded—a short, sharp blast signaling a shift change. The lioness straightened, casting one final glance at the hay before striding off, her bronze armor catching the haze-filtered light.

Aldric pulled straw from his hair, grinning like a fool. "That was close."

Nymira's heart was still hammering. She glared at him and kept moving.

Further along the outskirts of the settlement, the faint rustle of foliage signaled another threat. Nymira and Aldric froze as three hunters emerged from the Deepwoods, their lithe forms partially obscured by the reddish haze. Each wore light armor, their spears slung over their backs, and their sharp gazes scanned the area with precision.

“They’re getting too close,” Nymira whispered, her tone tense.

Aldric’s hand hovered over the hilt of his sword, but Nymira shook her head, already focused on a nearby tree. With a slow, deliberate movement, she extended her hand, and the bark seemed to groan in response. The tree’s massive branch bent, pressing against a precariously perched boulder. With a flick of her wrist, the boulder dislodged, tumbling down the slope and smashing into a stack of crates.

The hunters immediately turned toward the commotion, their attention drawn to the noise. Aldric and Nymira used the distraction to slip past, their footsteps muffled against the forest floor.

Finally, they arrived at the discreet side entrance, a stone door embedded into the base of the rock-hewn stronghold. It was guarded by two male Werelions who leaned lazily against the stone, their axes resting at their sides.

One of the lions yawned, his golden eyes half-lidded with boredom. “I hate these bottom feeder jobs,” he muttered.

The other grunted. “Try to enjoy it, it's not going to last long with the way Krugen Maar’s been riling everyone up.”

Nymira and Aldric remained hidden in the shadows, crouched low behind a dense bush. “Now what?” Nymira whispered, her voice barely audible.

“We wait,” Aldric murmured, his eyes fixed on the door. “Korva’s got to be close.”.

A loud horn blared from the front of the stronghold, its deep, resonant tone cutting through the night. Both guards straightened immediately, their ears swiveling toward the sound.

"Right on cue," Korva said, emerging from the shadows.

"Krugen Maar's speech," Korva explained, her voice low but steady. "He's addressing the increase in Hollowborn and rallying his troops for war against the Wereboars and Weregoats. Wants to push deeper into Farmire and the Deepwoods."

Nymira's brow furrowed as she processed the names. "Wereboars? Weregoats? I didn't even realize the Werebeast bloodline extended that far." Her tone had an edge to it, the frustration of someone whose understanding had been upended.

Korva's crimson eyes gleamed with faint amusement. "Your Aetherdren scholars have a lot of catching up to do. The Deep Woods are ancient, Twig. Bloodlines run deeper here than your charts and diagrams could ever map out." She gestured vaguely to the haze-filled settlement around them. "Here, it's Lions, Bears, and Ravens-" Korva with a quick glance at Aldric "Wolves." Past the Werelions? It's the Wereboars and Weregoats. And further? Well I hear whispers of Werecats, Werelizards and even stranger things like large mutated jellyfish floating around."

"Large- floating- Jellyfish?" Nymira started to ponder.

Aldric leaned back against the rock wall, crossing his arms casually. "No one really knows what's

beyond the Boars and Goats, though. Werelions don't exactly roll out the welcome mat. Mountains to the west, oceans to the east. Farmire's a straight line through the woods, past Tinmaal anyway. And anyone who tries to venture further doesn't exactly send back postcards."

Korva's beak-like grin widened. "Not alive, anyway."

Nymira's jaw tightened as she adjusted her satchel, her expression a storm of irritation and disbelief. "The 'higher-ups' in Terramechus—my peers, my colleagues—they've always acted like they know the full extent of Farmire. But they don't. They said the Werelions were the end of Farmire." Her voice grew sharper, more incredulous. "Why lie about something like that? Why not just admit they don't know. Why not send informants or diplomats? It worked with the Ravens and with the Wolves of Howl Valley. Why not extend that effort here?"

Aldric smirked, though it lacked his usual sharp edge. "Welcome to Farmire, Twig. Science and diplomats don't get much traction here—too much growling, clawing, and biting for that."

Nymira glared at him, unimpressed. "Well, I guess so." She let out a disbelieving laugh, shaking her head. "These are supposed to be the most respected minds in Terramechus, and they didn't even try. How can intelligent people ignore something so important? Why pretend they knew instead of just admitting they had more pressing matters? Sure, maybe they do, but it's an excuse. There's so much knowledge out here, so

much left to uncover—and they don't care!"

Korva let out a dry chuckle, her crimson eyes gleaming faintly in the dim light. "You're asking the wrong questions, Nymira. This isn't a place where knowledge is shared. Farmire is a place where power is fought over. If someone knows something here, it's because they bled for it, stole it, or killed for it. No one's going to hand it over for free, and no one in your pristine Terramechus is willing to dirty their hands to get it."

Nymira's gaze shifted to Aldric, her frustration now aimed squarely at him. "And you're just fine with that? Just accept it? Why try to make things better?" She shrugged.

"Look, Twig," Aldric said with a shrug of his own, his usual smirk fading into something more subdued, almost tired. "Out here, people are just trying to make it to tomorrow. The 'quest for knowledge' is a luxury most can't afford. And whether it's fair or not, out here, survival will always trump curiosity."

Nymira opened her mouth to argue, but Korva's sharp voice cut in. "Ok, let's save the philosophical debates for later. We've got work to do. That speech isn't going to last forever."

Korva shifted her weight, her crimson eyes sharp as she glanced toward the distant stronghold. "With the guards distracted, I'll slip inside and deal with any stragglers. Quietly. But let's be clear—this deal doesn't include dying for you two. Once the path is clear, I'm gone."

Nymira frowned, adjusting her satchel. “How convenient for you.”

Korva smirked, her feathers catching the faint light. “Convenient for all of us Nymira. I’ve done my part.”

Aldric stepped forward, his tone calm but resolute. “You’ve honored the deal. We’ll take it from here.”

“Good.” She paused at the edge of the door and glanced back. “Oh, and thanks again.”

“Just don’t go drinking that stuff,” Aldric with his grin returning. “I’m not sure I could ever take you seriously again—green glowing eyes, black scars aren’t really your look.”

Korva let out a low chuckle. “Relax, Aldric. I live to make money, not die chasing power. See you around—maybe.”

And with that, she slipped through the door, disappearing into the stronghold’s dark corridors.

Nymira exhaled softly, watching the door for a moment before looking at Aldric. “I’m really starting to hate this place.”

Aldric grinned, leaning against the stone wall. “Oh, come on, Twig. You’ll-grow into it.”

Nymira, with her plant-like features and a deadpan expression, gave him an unimpressed glance.

Aldric’s grin only widened. “See? That’s the spirit.”

Chapter 5: The Roar of the Pride

The heavy door creaked shut behind them, the sound muffled by the dense, red-orange haze that filled Tinmaal's air. Nymira adjusted her satchel, glancing uneasily at the unconscious lionesses sprawled across the stone floor. The bodies of the Werelion warriors were scattered with precision, as though Korva had choreographed her strikes with deadly efficiency. Their shallow, steady breathing confirmed her work had been non-lethal, but the sheer speed and stealth of her disappearance left a disquieting void.

"She's good," Aldric muttered, stepping carefully over a collapsed lioness whose spear was still clutched loosely in her paw. "Good enough that I'm glad she's on our side."

"For now," Nymira replied, her voice low but tense. She knelt briefly beside one of the unconscious warriors, her fingers brushing against the carved leather armor. "She took down an entire patrol without making a sound. That's... unsettling."

"That's Korva." Aldric shrugged, offering a faint grin as he straightened. "Leaves an impression, then vanishes before the applause."

Nymira rose to her feet, her amber eyes scanning the dim corridor. "She told us to head for the throne room, but with guards like this... I hope she left us more than breadcrumbs."

“Breadcrumbs? No,” Aldric said, gesturing to the scattered bodies. “More like a very clear warning. Let’s move.”

The corridors of the Werelion stronghold were like stepping into another world. Every inch of the stone walls was alive with intricate carvings, scenes of battle and triumph etched with painstaking detail. The lionesses, depicted with spears and shields, radiated pride and power. Each carving seemed to tell a story, a thread woven into the fabric of the Werelion’s fierce culture.

“Their craftsmanship—so precise,” Nymira said, her voice low as her fingers brushed a mural. The depiction of a lioness mid-hunt seemed almost alive, her spear poised to strike.

Aldric smirked, tilting his head at the carving. “You know, this is probably how they impress the ladies. ‘Hey, look what I chiseled today.’ Makes sense, though—have you seen the lionesses? I wouldn’t want to go home empty-handed to that.”

Nymira glared at him but didn’t reply, her eyes then adjusting to the piece of paper she removed from her pocket. “Ok, it seems we go this way.”

Korva’s makeshift map guided them through the twisting corridors. It was crude but accurate enough to keep them moving in the right direction. They turned a corner, and the low murmur of voices reached their ears, swelling with an occasional roar that made the stone underfoot vibrate.

“Up ahead,” Aldric whispered, pulling Nymira to the side as they approached a wide hallway leading to

an open balcony.

Peering around the corner, they saw the source of the commotion. Below, a massive chamber opened up, filled with a sea of Werelions. Above them, standing on a balcony draped in crimson banners, was Krugen Maar.

The chieftain's presence was impossible to ignore. Krugen Maar towered over the gathered warriors, his ceremonial armor catching the flickering torchlight, every plate polished to an almost blinding gleam. His mane of dreadlocks, streaked with deep crimson, framed a face both regal and menacing. Tattoos in blood-red patterns swirled across his chest and arms, highlighting the sleek, powerful muscle beneath his dark fur.

His golden eyes scanned the crowd, sharp and penetrating, exuding authority with every calculated movement. His stance was deliberate, commanding without effort, while the massive claws at the ends of his hands glinted faintly, as if itching for action.

When he spoke, his voice carried over the murmurs like a growl rising into a roar, every syllable imbued with strength and conviction. The energy in the room shifted, the warriors standing taller, their focus unwavering. Krugen Maar didn't just speak to his people; he owned the space, making it clear that this was his domain—and everyone within it was bound by his will.

Aldric nudged Nymira. "There's your guy. And the lions look like they'd follow him into hell."

“Shh,” Nymira hissed, her focus on the balcony as Krugen’s voice boomed, his words sharp and deliberate.

“Look at the weakness within the Boars and Goats,” his voice thundered. “They are a constant reminder of what complacency looks like. No progress. No power. No tenacity. And yet, they cling to their miserable lands as if they’ve earned them.”

A ripple of growls swept through the gathered Werelions, a sound like distant thunder. Krugen Maar raised a hand, silencing them instantly.

“Look at us,” he continued. “The women who wish to fight—I’ve made them the greatest warriors in all of Farmire. The men who sought to create—I’ve forged them into the finest artisans, craftsmen, and builders. Every detail of our society reflects our superiority. Even our meals are the envy of every tribe. We are the pinnacle of strength, and yet…”

He paused, his gaze sweeping over the crowd. The silence was electric, every warrior hanging on his words.

“The Hollowborn,” he sneered. “The concern of the weak. Look at Wererune. The Tombstone Order scurries about, pretending to be the answer. I ask you Werelions, Shall we do the same?”

The warriors roared in anger, their golden eyes blazing.

Krugen Maar’s voice rose, his claws outstretched. “No! My brothers and sisters, we are not caretakers! We are not crutches for feeble kingdoms! We are conquerors! We shall claim the lands of those too frail

to defend them. We will rise as the true rulers of Farmire!"

The hall erupted into a deafening roar, the sound reverberating through the corridors like an earthquake. Aldric and Nymira exchanged a wary glance as they pressed themselves further into the shadows.

"Nothing to worry about, right?" Nymira murmured, her voice dripping with sarcasm.

Aldric's lips curved into a tight grin. "Oh, sure—except something tells me that roar isn't just for show. Whatever the Codex means to him, it's got him riled up."

Nymira watched as the Werelion warriors began pounding their fists against their chests in unison—a rhythmic, thundering cadence that shook the very walls around them. The sound was primal, almost hypnotic. She could feel it in her bones, in the pit of her stomach. For all of Krugen's cruelty, she couldn't deny his power over his people. He didn't rule through fear alone—he ruled through belief. And that was far more dangerous.

"Is he really going to war with the boars and goats just because they struggle against Hollowborn?" she asked.

Aldric adjusted a strap, his usual levity absent for once. "He's not going to war because they're weak. He's going to war because he can. And because every conquest makes his people believe the next one is just as easy." He paused, listening to the pounding. "That's how empires start, Twig. One speech at a

time."

Nymira looked at him, surprised by the insight. Before she could respond, Aldric was already moving.

"We're on borrowed time. Let's go before that spark turns into a wildfire."

With a cautious glance to ensure the coast was clear, they slipped down the corridor, putting distance between themselves and the rising roar of the Werelions behind them.

At last, they reached the throne room door Korva had described. It was massive, a towering slab of steel etched with intricate patterns that glinted faintly in the dim torchlight. Nymira ran her hand along the surface, her brow furrowing.

"This isn't ordinary steel," Nymira murmured, her eyes narrowing as she examined the door. "The outer layers are nearly impenetrable, but the inner mechanisms... those are familiar. I can work with them."

Reaching into her satchel, she pulled out a leather glove intricately engraved with metallic vines that glinted faintly in the dim light. Sliding it on, she raised her hand, her fingers moving deftly through the air near the lock. The internal mechanics responded to her precise movements, shifting and clicking as she bent them to her will.

Aldric stood behind her, his sharp eyes scanning the corridor. "Gotta go faster, Twig. I've got a bad feeling about this."

She scoffed. "Do you even know how complex these mechanisms are? I need a minute."

As if on cue, the distant sound of footsteps echoed through the corridor. Both of them froze. The unmistakable clink of armor grew louder, and Aldric shot a glance at Nymira.

“Uh, almost done,” she whispered, her voice tight with panic.

Aldric grimaced, then dropped to his knees. “Follow my lead,” he hissed.

“What—” Nymira began, but Aldric grabbed her arm, tugging her down beside him. Confused but desperate, she mimicked his posture, sitting back on her knees with her hands resting in her lap.

The lioness guard came into view. She froze, her sharp golden eyes narrowing as she processed the absurd scene in front of her. “What in the Deep Woods are you two doing here?” she demanded, her voice sharp but laced with confusion.

Aldric straightened his posture slightly, putting on a disarmingly wide grin. “Ah, are you here to help with the luxurious... service?” he asked, his tone dripping with faux innocence.

“Service?” The word came out as a bewildered bark, her spear lowering slightly as her ears flicked forward.

“Yes!” Aldric exclaimed, gesturing enthusiastically between himself and Nymira. “You know, the “Luxurious accommodations Lord Krugen Maar requested. A Werewolf and an Aetherdren—quite a unique taste, but hey, who are we to judge?”

The lioness blinked, her grip on her spear faltering. “What... what are you talking about?” she

stammered, the confusion on her face now plain as day.

Nymira's lips twitched, caught between mortification and outright fury. Aldric, however, pressed on, undeterred. "We were paid for, escorted all the way here, and specifically told to wait for Lord Krugen Maar's... uh... stress relief needs."

"Stress—what?" The lioness's voice cracked, her tail puffing slightly in pure bewilderment. Her eyes darted nervously down the hallway, as if hoping someone else might miraculously appear to take over this bizarre encounter.

Aldric leaned forward slightly, lowering his voice conspiratorially. "You know, after a big speech, it's understandable. All that roaring and inspiring—it takes a toll."

The lioness's ears flattened against her head, and the blush creeping under her fur deepened to a crimson hue. "No I—he—what?!" she sputtered, her composure slipping entirely. She shifted awkwardly, glancing between the two of them like she had walked into the middle of some absurd play and was now the butt of the joke.

Finally, she let out a strangled sound that was somewhere between a growl and a whimper. "Fine. Just—stay here and don't touch anything!" she snapped, spinning on her heel so quickly her tail nearly knocked over a torch sconce. She stomped quickly back down the hall, muttering furiously to herself, her tail lashing behind her in what could only be described as mortified fury.

As soon as she was gone, Nymira shot Aldric a withering glare. “Luxurious accommodations? Stress relief? Are you kidding me?”

“Hey, it worked didn't it?” Aldric said, his grin returning. “And you’ve got to admit, I sold it.”

“You’re insufferable.”

“Charming, you mean?” he corrected. “Now hurry up. She won’t stay gone forever.”

Nymira returned to the door, her fingers deftly manipulating the bending tool as she focused on the lock. The steel groaned in protest, but soon there was a soft click. She exhaled in relief, stepping back as the massive door began to shift.

The dark, ominous interior of the throne room loomed ahead, the flickering torchlight barely illuminating its vast expanse. Nymira glanced at Aldric, her expression a mix of determination and unease.

“Ready?” she asked.

“Just another day in Farmire,” he replied, his grin softening into something more resolute.

Together, they stepped inside.

Chapter 6: Finding the Codex

The throne room exuded an air of power, its grandeur both intimidating and mysterious. Aldric and Nymira stepped cautiously inside, the heavy door creaking shut behind them. Light filtered through high, narrow windows, casting angular shadows that danced across the intricately carved stone walls. Every inch of the chamber seemed to tell a story of Werelion supremacy: battle scenes immortalized in stone, banners of crimson and gold draped across the walls, and weapons mounted like trophies.

Nymira's eyes immediately locked onto the centerpiece of the room—a massive steel and bronze statue of a Werelion, its towering form both regal and menacing. The statue was posed with one paw raised, claws gripping an object. A dense, spiked orb resembling a petrified seed, intricately adorned with engraved runes and metallic vines that radiate an aura of ancient power and guarded secrets. the Codex of Thorns. The thorned surface glinted faintly in the dim light, its dense, seed-like structure exuding a sense of weight and importance even from a distance.

"Is that-" Aldric asks, nodding toward the statue. "Is that our prize?"

Nymira gives Aldric a slow nod then approaches the statue cautiously, her amber eyes scanning its details. The craftsmanship was extraordinary—every muscle in the Werelion's body seemed to ripple with life, and the claws gripping the Codex appeared

unyielding. The statue wasn't just a display of artistry; it was a challenge.

"It's locked in there tight," she said, her voice tinged with frustration. "I'll have to bend it out."

Aldric leaned against a nearby pillar, watching her with an arched brow. "Can you do it?"

Nymira raised a hand, her fingers moving in deliberate, precise motions as she focused her bending abilities on the statue's claws. The air around her seemed to hum faintly as she pulled at the metal, attempting to reshape it. But the steel and bronze resisted, immovable against her efforts. Beads of sweat formed on her brow as she pushed harder, but the statue remained steadfast.

She exhaled sharply, lowering her hand. "It's no use. Bending takes a lot of strength and knowledge—strength to manipulate dense materials like this, and knowledge of the metal's properties. Unfortunately, right now, I'm lacking both."

"So we're stuck?" Aldric asked, stepping closer to inspect the statue.

Nymira shook her head, her gaze shifting to the statue's arms and fingers. "Not necessarily. Look at the mechanics here. The arms and claws—they're not solid. There's a mechanism, a way to unlock the Codex without brute force."

Aldric squinted, following her line of sight. "Interesting… but where's the key?"

His attention was drawn to a nearby table, where a collection of small stone statues was scattered haphazardly. He motioned for Nymira to join him.

“Take a look at this.”

The table was covered with miniature statues, each intricately carved and distinct. Some were upright, while others had toppled over, as if knocked down in haste. Nymira examined them closely, her eyes lighting up with recognition.

“These represent kingdoms and nations,” she said, picking up a statue resembling an Aetherdren. “Here’s one for the Werelions, one for Howl Valley… and some I don’t recognize.”

Aldric pointed to a brass plaque mounted on the edge of the table. The inscription read:

“In the presence of might, the meek shall bow,

With one left standing, the path shows how.”

Nymira’s lips curved into a thoughtful smile. “It’s a puzzle.”

“Krugen likes puzzles?” Aldric muttered, though there was a flicker of interest in his eyes.

Ignoring him, Nymira began arranging the statues. “The inscription implies submission. The lesser kingdoms bow to the greatest— The Werelions. Simple, I believe we just lay down all the statues except for the Werelion.”

“Seems like a bit of ego stroking,” Aldric remarked, but he helped her carefully knock over the other statues, leaving only the Werelion figure upright.

The moment the last statue was placed, a faint click echoed through the room. A section of the wall behind the table slid open, revealing a small, glowing object nestled in a recessed compartment.

Nymira's eyes widened. "A Mantle Sphere?"

The sphere was no larger than a rock used to skip across a pond, glowing faintly with an internal light that shifted between red and orange. Its surface was smooth, almost liquid-like, yet solid to the touch. The ambient Mantle energy in the room seemed to bend toward it, drawn like iron filings to a magnet.

"Why would Krugen Maar have this?" Nymira wondered aloud, picking it up carefully. The Mantle Sphere pulsed in her hands, its hum resonating through her fingertips and up her arms. She could feel its power—raw, concentrated Mantle energy, far denser than anything she'd worked with in Terramechus. It was like holding a tiny sun.

"It's magic craft," she continued, turning it over with reverent precision. "Spellcasters in Wererune forge these by compressing raw Mantle energy into a crystalline matrix. The process takes weeks and requires a level of magical precision that most benders can only dream of. This one feels old—decades, maybe centuries. How it ended up in a Werelion stronghold in the middle of Farmire..."

Aldric leaned in, his expression curious but cautious. "Rare here, sure. But in Wererune? They're uncommon but available enough that if you wanted one, you could probably buy one. Still, why it's here? I couldn't say. War trophy, maybe. Or a trade."

Nymira's brow furrowed as her fingers tightened around the sphere. Her voice took on a sharp, mocking edge. "Magic craft like this... it's so childish. All that ridiculous posturing and overblown theatrics

just to conjure some flashy element out of thin air? Please." She scoffed. "Why not just bend what the planet already provides? Real power doesn't need cheap tricks—it's about mastering what's already there, not crafting temporary nonsense like some street performer. Her tone grew harsher with each word, her grip on the sphere whitening her knuckles. "Why create tools like this just so they can be stolen? What's the point? To let power fall into the hands of people like Krugen Maar? It's absurd! Dangerous!"

Aldric shifted uneasily. "Uh, Twig, maybe—"

Her words became more venomous, her voice trembling with anger. "No one should have access to this. It's reckless! The spellcasters—they just keep creating without thought! Fools, every single one of them!" She then stopped abruptly, her voice catching in her throat as her breathing quickened. Her eyes darted to Aldric, her face a mixture of confusion and alarm. "Why am I...?"

Aldric's expression darkened. "Hand it over."

"What?" Nymira shot back, gripping the sphere tightly. "But I found it!"

"Now, Twig," Aldric said, his voice steady but firm. "Its the Mantle Sphere. Give it here."

Snapping back into realization, she reluctantly passed the sphere to him. The moment it left her hands, she felt the anger fade away, replaced by a wave of clarity.

"Right," she said, her tone softer. "Because Werebeast can't use magic."

Aldric pocketed the sphere, his jaw tightening. “True. But I know a thing or two about compressing rage.”

The weight of his words hung in the air for a moment allowing Nymira some time to understand. Without wanting to pry for more info she broke the silence. “Where does it go?”

Aldric tilted his head, studying the mantle sphere. "Big, gaudy, and symbolic—classic Krugen Maar. It’s like those old stories where kings would drink from jeweled goblets to feel like gods.” He smirked. “He flaunts the power like he owns it, but he can’t really use it. Bet he’d love to consume that raw power if he could.”

Nymira followed his gaze, her eyes narrowing as realization dawned. “Consume-You think, the statue…?”

“The statue?” Aldric repeated, raising an eyebrow.

“Yes—its mouth,” Nymira said, as if it were the most obvious conclusion.

Aldric blinked, confused. “Uh, Twig, I wasn’t being literal.”

Nymira shrugged. “Far-fetched? Sure. But sometimes that’s how science works—abstract ideas solving simple problems. “Like discovering medicines from mold. Something gross ended up saving so many.””

Aldric stared at her, then broke into a confident grin. “Alright, genius. Let’s see if you’re right.”

He reached up and carefully placed the Mantle Sphere into the open mouth of the statue. The sphere

fit perfectly, and the moment it clicked into place, the statue began to shift, the grinding of stone echoing through the chamber.

The arms lowered slowly, the fingers releasing their grip on the Codex. The room filled with the sound of grinding metal as the statue came to life, fulfilling its symbolic gesture of consuming power and granting access to its prize.

Nymira stepped forward, cradling the Codex of Thorns as it was released. Its thorned surface felt both alien and familiar, its weight heavier than expected. She turned it over in her hands, marveling at its craftsmanship and density.

"We've got it," she said, her voice steady despite the tremor in her hands.

"Yeah," Aldric said, his grin returning. "Now let's get out of here before someone notices."

The heavy door creaked open, sending a chill through the room. Aldric and Nymira froze mid-step, their eyes darting to the nearest hiding spots. They barely had time to duck into the shadows before the towering figure of Krugen Maar strode into the chamber.

His mane, streaked with crimson, shimmered faintly in the dim light. His golden eyes burned with a predatory intensity, sharp enough to cut through the gloom. Every step he took was deliberate, his heavy claws clicking faintly against the stone floor. Beside him was a smaller Werelion in ceremonial robes, holding a slate of stone and parchment—his advisor, Vivic. While smaller in stature, Vivic's sharp features

and meticulous bearing radiated competence, if not intimidation.

Krugen Maar inhaled deeply, his gaze settling on the golden statue. He exhaled slowly, his voice low and guttural. “Do they take us for fools?”

Vivic nodded quickly, his tone crisp. “Of course not, Sire. The enemy will kneel before your will.”

Krugen’s eyes narrowed as he began to pace, a clawed finger resting on his chin. “Is it ignorance or bravery, Vivic?”

The advisor raised a cautious eyebrow. “Sire?”

Krugen stopped pacing, his claws lightly dragging along the edge of a table. His voice dipped into something quieter, almost contemplative. “Do you not understand the prophecies passed down from the days of old? The tales of beasts who could ascend, transcending what we are now? Becoming something greater. Something more… divine. The Werejackals.”

Vivic hesitated, clearly uncertain where the conversation was headed. “Yes, Sire. The concept of ascension would—would be… extraordinary.”

Krugen Maar ignored him, walking to a nearby window overlooking Tinmaal’s vast expanse. His gaze swept across the warriors below, who were still roaring their approval of his earlier speech.

“The Pale Weaver,” Krugen rumbled, his voice sharpening. “The Pale Weaver has returned, her knowledge will bring the path to ascension.”

Vivic straightened, his ears flicking in nervous anticipation. “If the rumors are true, Sire, we could—”

Krugen turned abruptly, silencing Vivic with a wave of his massive hand. “The tablets of old found in the depths of Farmire—in caves so deep that no light has touched them since the world was young—they tell of the Werejackals’ rule. Beasts tied to the Mantle, wielding magic and bending matter. Not crude spellcasting like those charlatans in Wererune. True power. The ability to reshape reality itself.”

He began pacing again, his claws clicking against the stone in a steady rhythm. “And ultimately—combining dark matter and dark magic to become something even more. An Anubis.”

Vivic blinked, clearly struggling to follow his leader’s thoughts.

“Do you understand what that means?” Krugen demanded, wheeling on his advisor. “Not just a warrior. Not just a king. An Anubis stood between life and death, between the physical world and whatever lies beyond it. They could judge the living and command the dead. They could tear open the fabric between dimensions and stitch it back together.”

He spread his arms, his deep voice booming with conviction. “Imagine it. The power to shape the world itself. To sculpt the very earth. To summon life or destroy it with a mere thought. To become a god.”

His laughter echoed through the chamber, rich and full of menace.

Vivic cleared his throat cautiously. “It would… certainly be a grand achievement, Sire.”

Krugen stepped closer to the golden statue, his voice lowering but his tone no less intense. “Our

ancestors sought to ascend once again after the Anubis fell. All they needed was the beast blood and the Pale Weavers knowledge, a dark spell no less. And what stopped them?"

Vivic hesitated but stayed silent, sensing the rhetorical nature of the question.

Krugen sneered, his voice growing sharper with disdain. "The failures of the past. The wolves of Howl Valley, those miserable tamebloods of Wererune, and their precious King Oxren. They let the Pale Weaver's knowledge slip through their claws, leaving it to Oxren to wield as a mere bargaining chip. And what did it gain them? Exile. When Oxren fell, the tamebloods turned on the wolves, berating and attacking them until they were cast out of Wererune. Left to rot on the outskirts of the Deep Woods. Stupid, blind fools."

He laughed bitterly, shaking his head. "Stupid, just like the dogs you are."

Hidden behind a nearby wardrobe, Aldric shot Nymira a sidelong glance. His expression seemed to ask, Is he talking about me? Nymira looked just as baffled.

Krugen's tone shifted again, this time to something eerily calm. "But we? We are not like them. We have the blood, Vivic. We have the Codex of Thorns. And a Spelltracer who will use the soil to track us to the Pale Weaver. A marvelous hunt indeed. And then- Her magic will belong to us."

Vivic finally found his voice, eager to reaffirm his loyalty. "With you leading us, Sire, I have no doubt we

will succeed. You've never failed us."

Krugen turned to him, a grin spreading across his face. "No, Vivic. I haven't, have I? But it's always good to hear it from someone else."

With a flourish, Krugen placed his hands on the wardrobe's ornate handles. His grin widened, and his voice took on a mocking lilt. "And speaking of dogs…"?"

The wardrobe creaked open, and there they were. Nymira and Aldric stared back at Krugen Maar, frozen in place.

Krugen's golden eyes glinted with triumph. "What have we here?"

Chapter 7: A Captive Plan

Aldric's eyes fluttered open to the familiar metallic tang of blood in his mouth and the steady drip of water from somewhere overhead. The cell was dimly lit, the flickering light from a lone torch in the hallway casting long, uneven shadows on the damp stone walls. The scent of iron, sweat, and something heavier—anticipation—clung to the air.

Beyond the bars, distant roars and the rhythmic clash of weapons echoed through the stronghold.

"Lovely accommodations," a familiar voice muttered from the neighboring cell.

Aldric turned his head to see Nymira sitting up, rubbing her wrists. Her fingers brushed the iron bars with distaste. Despite the chaos that had led to their capture, her satchel was still strapped across her shoulder, albeit noticeably lighter.

"And all equipped with iron bars and massive locks, with no one else here? What an honor," Aldric said dryly, his sharp eyes scanning the empty cells around them.

Nymira shrugged, brushing a strand of silver hair from her face. "Not shocking. The Werelions are disciplined enough to keep things in order, I suppose." She glanced at the empty cells and furrowed her brow. "Still, I don't see why no other Werelion has stood up to him. What could Krugen Maar possibly offer them?"

"A future," Aldric replied simply.

Nymira turned to him, her amber eyes narrowing in confusion. “A future? No one was threatening them. It’s not like they were under attack.”

Aldric leaned back against the wall, his expression thoughtful but tinged with a quiet bitterness. “The Werelions’ enemy isn’t some outside force—it’s complacency. They’re not fighting for survival, Twig. They’re fighting against feeling useless, irrelevant. ‘Boring’ is the new enemy, and Krugen Maar offers them a purpose.

Nymira gave him a wary look, her lips pressing into a thin line. Before she could respond, her ears twitched, catching a faint sound echoing down the hallway.

“Wait,” she whispered, her voice tight. She tilted her head, straining to listen. “I can hear them coming.”

Before Aldric could respond, the sound of heavy footsteps began to grow louder. The torchlight flared, casting long, flickering shadows along the wall.

Krugen Maar strode into view, his ceremonial armor gleaming as though freshly polished for the occasion. The Codex of Thorns rested in one massive claw, its dark, thorned surface catching the light like a malevolent jewel. Two guards flanked him, their golden eyes locked onto their prisoners, their polished axes glinting ominously.

But it wasn’t just the guards. A third figure leaned casually against the far wall—a shadow draped in black leather, its face obscured by a hood with two horns peering out. The figure’s arms were crossed,

fingers long and sharp, resting lightly on their forearms. A long, scaly tail with ridges like iron coils flicked lazily behind them.

Aldric's eyes narrowed. "Another guest? How marvelous." He feigned excitement, raising his hands in mock cheer. "Is it bring-your-own-beast day?"

Krugen's lips curled into a slow, amused grin. "No beast blood in him." His tone was almost indulgent. "But useful nonetheless."

Nymira stiffened. Her eyes widened slightly as recognition dawned. "The Spelltracer I assume," she whispered.

Aldric's smirk faltered as he glanced at her. "Wait... you're saying this guy's real? Thought he'd might be talking out out ass to be honest." Then the shadowy figure pushed off the wall and stepped forward, pulling back his hood. His features were angular and sharp, with blue-grey scales that shimmered faintly in the torchlight. His eyes were pale blue, unnervingly calm, yet crackling with an undercurrent of restrained power. Two dark, curved horns jutted back from his brow, framing his face.

Aldric blinked. "A Drakai?" His voice dropped an octave in disbelief. "Wait-Really? You've got to be kidding me."

The Drakai moved his hands with swift, precise gestures—sign language. His expression remained stoic as his sharp fingers danced through the air.

Nymira and Aldric exchanged puzzled glances, unable to decipher the signs.

Krugen's grin widened as he watched their confusion. "A mute," he said, almost reverently. "But one with an exceptional gift." His voice lowered, rich with pride. "Zareek can track spells back to their origin—their creators. He can track magic like a wolf tracks prey. Makes for a most effective assassin, don't you think?"

Aldric folded his arms, raising an eyebrow. "Or for finding out who's shirking on their duties. What's next, Zareek sniffing out who's using magic to clean the latrines?"

Krugen's smile never faltered. "Laugh while you can, dog. The time is near and I'm in a charitable mood. I'll even let you walk free—"

Aldric's smirk deepened. "With a red carpet and a fancy feast?"

Krugen's golden eyes narrowed, his tone dipping into mock sincerity. "Return to Howl Valley. Convince that useless Ermok to finally do something worthwhile—wage war against the Aetherdren."

Nymira let out a small gasp, drawing Krugen's attention. His smug grin widened as he turned his gaze toward her. "Yes, the tree beings of Terramechus," he sneered. "Farting around in the woods like children with toys. They prattle on about advancements and breakthroughs, not realizing the only reason they still exist is because the Werebeasts allow it. Pathetic."

He turned his focus back to Aldric, his expression hard and unyielding. "Terramechus and Howl Valley are the only gateway through the Deep Woods into

Wererune. After I start the attack, the Aetherdren will come running for help. Wipe them out. Burn Terramechus to the ground and save me the trouble."

Krugen's grin widened, the edges sharp with malice. "Do that, and I'll welcome the werewolves back with open arms. You can finally reclaim your place in the pack."

Nymira turned to Aldric, her disbelief plain on her face.

For a moment, Aldric's cocky grin faltered. The words "welcome the werewolves back" hit harder than any claw. He knew what that meant—a home, an end to exile, a chance to walk through Vaulhold's markets without people crossing the street. Everything he'd lost the day he'd saved those farmers and been rewarded with their terror.

But the price. Burn Terramechus. Kill the Aetherdren. Kill people like Nymira—scientists, scholars, children who were learning to bend their first sapling.

He caught himself quickly, forcing his features back into a mask of smug indifference. "Sorry, King," he said with a mocking shrug. "Looks like you'll have to chop your own firewood."

Krugen's laughter rumbled low and deep, but his eyes remained cold, calculating. "We shall see, dog," he growled.

Nymira, her eyes locked on Zareek, spoke up suddenly. "But why would a Drakai help Werebeasts? You're divided by the mountains that pierce the sky."

Zareek’s fingers moved again, faster this time—his motions laced with frustration.

Electricity sparked from his fingertips, sending a faint hum through the air.

Krugen’s expression softened, almost fond. “Easy, Zareek. She doesn’t know. Their books and leaders show how naive their knowledge is of the outside world. She doesn't know of your people’s suffering under the Aurora. Complacency breeds ignorance.”

Zareek’s shoulders relaxed, and he turned away, leaning back against the wall.

Krugen’s attention returned to Nymira, his voice almost casual. "And you… What’s the best use for a spriggan like you?" He emphasized the slur, watching as Nymira’s face flushed with anger.

Her fists clenched at her sides, but she held her tongue.

Krugen leaned in, his smile razor-sharp. "Perhaps I could turn your leaders’ heads. A bargaining chip to sow discord. But no… I’ll conquer those lands soon enough. Maybe the dog is right? Aetherdren would make for such lovely firewood." He let out a mocking laugh.

Nymira’s breath was shallow, her knuckles white.

Krugen straightened and turned toward Zareek. “Shall we?”

Zareek pushed off the wall and followed, his tail swaying behind him. The guards filed out after them, leaving the torch light to flicker in their absence. The iron door groaned shut, locking Aldric and Nymira back in silence.

“Guess he’s not used to handling Artificials,” Nymira muttered, already focusing on the lock. Her fingers moved with practiced precision, bending the inner components one by one. The iron mechanisms clicked and shifted under her touch, yielding to her expertise despite the crude construction. “I can bend this mechanism—no problem.”

She paused, her brow furrowing. “But all this killing and stealing… it doesn’t make sense. He has an entire nation behind him—warriors, artisans, builders. Why not use that to build something? Trade with the outside? Open borders?”

Aldric leaned against the wall, watching her work. “Because that requires trust. And nobody in Farmire trusts anybody. You saw it yourself—the Ravens scam each other for coin, the Lions bully everything that moves, and the Bears hide in their mountains.” His tone was flat but thoughtful. “Survival’s been hammered into Krugen so hard that he thinks being the strongest means being the safest. But as long as ascension exists—as long as there’s even a chance that some Werebeast could drink the right water and become something beyond mortal—he has to be the one who gets there first. Because if someone else does? Everything he’s built crumbles.”

Nymira’s movements slowed as she considered his words. “Logical, but foolish. Safety isn’t about brute force—it’s built through trade, understanding, and trust. Nobody wants to die. If we worked together, we could all be better.”

“Tell that to the farmers who ran me out of town for saving their lives,” Aldric said quietly.

Nymira looked at him sharply, but his expression was unreadable.

With a final click, the lock sprung open.

“Let me get that for you,” Aldric said smoothly, pushing open her cell door before she could react.

“Thank you,” Nymira said instinctively, only to blink in confusion as she realized Aldric was already out of his own cell. “Wait—how did you—”

“Come on, Twig,” Aldric interrupted, gesturing for her to follow. “We’ve got to move. Fast.”

Shaking her head, Nymira adjusted her satchel and hurried after him. “Wait!” she called, her voice tinged with both irritation and urgency.

Chapter 8: The Gambler's Entrance

Nymira hurried after Aldric, her boots barely making a sound against the cold stone floor. They slipped through the labyrinthine corridors of the stronghold, keeping to the shadows. The muffled echoes of Krugen's voice carried through the stone, rising and falling like a sermon.

Then, they reached the doors leading to the courtyard. Aldric pressed a hand against the heavy wood, exhaling sharply.

"You ready?" he asked, glancing at Nymira.

"Not really," she admitted, adjusting her satchel.

"Perfect." With a firm push, Aldric swung the doors open.

The courtyard was vast—an open expanse of packed earth and stone, ringed by towering walls carved with scenes of conquest. Torches guttered in iron brackets, their flames casting shadows that danced like spectators awaiting a show. Werelion warriors stood in clusters, their golden eyes turning toward the doors with a mixture of surprise and predatory interest.

And at the center of it all, surrounded by his most loyal warriors, stood Krugen Maar.

He slowly turned his head toward them, tilting it slightly like a predator sizing up prey. His golden eyes gleamed as he fully faced them, his massive frame

casting a long shadow across the courtyard. The Codex of Thorns gleamed in his grip, its thorned surface catching the firelight.

“So… you’ve come to die?” he asked, voice low but carrying a dangerous weight. He chuckled, the sound cold and mocking.

Aldric and Nymira stood in the doorway, exposed, outnumbered, and completely without a plan. The realization hit Nymira like a physical blow—they had escaped their cells, navigated the stronghold, and made it this far, only to walk directly into the worst possible scenario. Every Werelion in the courtyard was now staring at them. There was no sneaking past this.

Krugen shook his head in disbelief, taking a few slow steps forward. "Desperation makes fools of us all. Look before you." He gestured grandly to the mass of Werelion warriors surrounding him. “This. This is what I’ve built. You thought you’d ‘save the day’?” He laughed louder this time, and several of the nearby Werelions joined in, their chuckles echoing off the stone walls like hyenas circling their prey.

He raised the Codex of Thorns high. "It’s over. We will never live like scavengers again." He strode toward Zareek, his tail flicking behind him. “Now, Spelltracer. Do your work. Find the Pale Weaver.”

Zareek stepped forward without hesitation. His scaled hands moved over the Codex in intricate gestures, lightning-like arcs crackling from his fingertips. The surface of the artifact pulsed with dark energy, faint glyphs flickering like fading embers.

"No!" Nymira shouted, her voice cracking with urgency. Aldric clenched his fists, his growl low and threatening.

Before either could act, an eerie horn blast cut through the air. It was deep and resonant, vibrating through stone and bone alike. The courtyard fell into a sudden, unnatural silence. Zareek's hands froze mid-gesture, the crackling energy sputtering out as he turned toward the sound.

Krugen stiffened, his golden eyes narrowing dangerously as he scanned the treeline beyond the courtyard. The entire landscape fell eerily silent, with only the faint crackling of fire and the distant chirp of crickets breaking the stillness. Krugen's growl rumbled low in his throat before he finally shattered the tension.

"Vivic!" he barked.

His advisor came rushing to his side. "Sire! A war horn... it's unfamiliar. It could belong to any faction—"

A second horn blast echoed, louder and closer this time. Everyone, including Zareek and Vivic, shifted toward the sound, their movements hesitant and uncertain, unsure of what action to take.

Krugen's lips curled into a snarl. He stomped forward, the Codex lowered to his side. His boots hit the ground like thunder, each step reverberating ominously. "What is this?" he muttered darkly.

A third horn shattered the tense quiet. Then the shadows at the edge of the tree line stirred. At first, the movement was subtle, like wind blowing leaves on

a trees. Then the ground shook as hundreds of figures broke from the treeline in a sudden, overwhelming rush.

“Werebears and Werecrows!” Vivic cried, his voice panicked. “They've allied… but how?”

Krugen’s fury boiled over. He threw back his head and roared. "Lions to arms! Kill the maggots! No one survives!"

The Werelion warriors sprang into action. Spears clashed with swords, and the courtyard exploded into chaos. Smoke bombs detonated, shrouding the battlefield in thick, acrid clouds. Gunshots echoed alongside the clang of steel. Arrows rained down in deadly arcs, while Werebears in heavy, battle-scarred armor bulldozed through the lines, their claws tearing through stone and flesh alike.

The Werecrows darted through the chaos like wraiths, their leather armor gleaming in the dim light. Some launched themselves from trees, their wings spread wide, raining down arrows and bombs before vanishing into the smoke. Others fought alongside the Werebears, their blades flashing in quick, brutal strikes.

Amidst the onslaught, a single, commanding presence emerged. Perched atop the shoulder of a massive, rampaging Werebear was a female Werecrow, adorned in regal, ornately patterned armor and jewelry that glittered like starlight. She balanced effortlessly as the Werebear tore through a cluster of Werelions, her long rifle cracking with each precise shot.

“Krugen Maar!” she called out, her voice carrying with an almost regal authority. “Did you think we would sit by and watch you destroy us?!”

Krugen’s eyes widened in rage, his mind struggling to process the sudden ambush. He raised the Codex, trying to refocus. But before he could issue another command, the ground beneath his feet rumbled.

A towering wall of stone erupted between him and the battlefield, blocking his path. Dust and debris filled the air as the barrier rose to full height.

Krugen's eyes darted across the towering wall, his mind racing to piece together what had just happened. Realization struck like a spark, and his head snapped around, locking onto Nymira. Her arms were outstretched, her face pale and strained with the effort of bending the stone.

Without a moment's hesitation, Krugen let out a deafening roar dropping the Codex and charging straight at her.

Nymira barely had time to react, raising a wall of stone spikes to slow him down. The spikes shattered against his bulk, and she stumbled back, her heart racing.

Before Krugen could reach her, a silver blur slammed into his side, knocking him off balance. Aldric, now fully transformed into his Werewolf form, growled low and menacing.

The transformation had been instantaneous—one moment, the cocky, silver-haired rogue; the next, a beast. Nymira had seen drawings of werewolves in

Terramechus textbooks, clinical sketches with labeled anatomy and detached observations. None of them had prepared her for this.

Aldric stepped forward, his movements fluid and predatory, the moonlight glinting off his silver-gray fur. In his werewolf form, he was an imposing figure—hulking, broad-shouldered, with claws like black steel and eyes that glowed like molten amber. His snout curled into a silent snarl, exposing razor-sharp fangs. He was terrifying. He was also, unmistakably, still Aldric—she could see it in the way he positioned himself between her and Krugen, in the way his ears flicked toward her to confirm she was still standing.

This was what he'd been afraid of. This was what had gotten him cast out of Wererune. And he'd done it anyway—for her, for the mission, for the people he refused to admit he cared about.

Krugen Maar stood tall and unfazed, his mane rippling in the flickering torchlight. His golden eyes narrowed, gleaming with a mix of fury and bloodlust. He rolled his massive shoulders and flexed his claws.

“Not so tamed after all," Krugen growled, his voice low and dangerous, each word laced with disdain. The tension between them crackled like a coiled storm ready to break. He bared his fangs in a cruel grin. "To die with some integrity, right? Pfft... I’ll put you down like the mutt you are.”

Aldric didn’t flinch. Instead, he took a step forward, his claws digging into the stone with a deliberate scrape, a low rumble vibrating from his

throat. The two titans locked eyes, the air between them growing thick with anticipation.

The two clashed with explosive fury—a whirlwind of claws, teeth, and flashing steel. Aldric's movements were swift and precise, a deadly dance of offense and defense. His sword gleamed under the flickering torchlight as he slashed and ducked, each strike aimed with expert precision. In one fluid motion, he hurled the blade like a spear, the weapon embedding itself deep into Krugen's side. With a snarl, Aldric yanked it free, spinning back into a fighting stance.

Nymira wasn't a bystander. Her hands moved with purpose, bending the environment around them. Gnarled roots surged from beneath the ground, wrapping around Krugen's legs like serpents. Stone spikes jutted up from the floor, aimed to impale, but Krugen was an unstoppable force. Roaring with fury, he tore through the roots with brute strength, shattering the stone with a single stomp.

Krugen fought like a tank—every blow heavy and merciless. His claws ripped through the air, each swipe carrying enough force to shatter bone. Aldric narrowly dodged one strike but couldn't avoid the next. A powerful backhand sent him sprawling across the chamber floor. As Aldric scrambled to his feet, Krugen's muscular tail lashed out like a whip, catching him off guard and sweeping his legs out from under him.

The ground trembled under Krugen's footsteps as he pressed forward, his eyes burning with rage.

Despite their relentless efforts, Krugen's sheer power began to overtake them like a rising tide. His movements, once slow and methodical, grew more aggressive—each strike faster and heavier than the last. He ripped through Nymira's stone barriers with brutal ease, his claws carving through her creations as if they were paper. She bent roots to entangle his feet again, gasping from the effort, but they snapped under the force of his kicks.

"I can't hold him much longer!" Nymira cried, sweat dripping from her brow as her bending faltered. The earth around her trembled with her failing control, each new barrier crumbling moments after forming.

Aldric snarled in a guttural growl, his werewolf form battered but refusing to yield.

Krugen let out a deep, mocking chuckle. "Tired already, little spriggan?" he taunted, effortlessly dodging another stone spike as if it were a mere inconvenience. His eyes gleamed with bloodlust as he bore down on Aldric. "You fight well, mutt, but even wild beasts know when they're beaten."

With a roar that shook the air, Krugen lunged. Aldric braced himself, but Krugen's claws connected in a crushing blow to his chest, sending Aldric hurtling through the air. He crashed into the stone wall with earth-shattering force, the entire barrier crumbling around him in a deafening explosion of dust and rubble.

"Aldric!" Nymira screamed, staggering as the shockwave knocked her back.

The dust cleared, revealing Aldric sprawled in the open courtyard beyond the shattered wall, motionless. Nymira stumbled forward, her voice hoarse as she called out to him again, desperation clawing at her throat.

Krugen stepped through the breach, his massive frame silhouetted by the chaotic fires of the stronghold. He rolled his neck, muscles rippling beneath his dark fur. “Dogs like you don’t belong here in Farmire. A waste of time and waste of beast blood”

Aldric lay sprawled and unmoving as the chaos of battle surged around him—shouts, clashing steel, and roars echoed across the courtyard. Dust and smoke swirled in the flickering firelight, painting the scene in a nightmare haze.

Krugen Maar loomed at the edge of the rubble, his golden eyes narrowing with satisfaction. He rolled his shoulders, cracking his neck with a slow, deliberate motion as he marched forward. His muscles bulged, veins standing out as he crouched and seized a massive boulder, effortlessly lifting it above his head. The ground seemed to tremble under the weight of his strength, and warriors on both sides paused to witness the grim spectacle.

He took slow, purposeful steps toward Aldric, each one sending echoes through the broken stones. The boulder cast a looming shadow over the fallen Werewolf, his frame dwarfed beneath the weight of Krugen’s impending strike.

“Nothing personal,” Krugen murmured coldly, his tone suddenly calm and almost pitiful. He smirked,

baring his fangs. “Just survival.”

With a savage roar, Krugen raised the boulder higher, preparing to bring it down in a single, crushing blow.

Nymira’s heart raced as she saw the boulder rise higher. “No!” she screamed, her hand reaching out instinctively.

Chapter 9: The Gambler's Last Bet

The battlefield of Tinmaal was chaos incarnate—roars, steel, and smoke blending into a furious storm. Amidst it all, Krugen Maar stood, holding a massive boulder high above his head, poised to crush Aldric's limp body beneath its weight.

Nymira, breathless and battered, screamed, "No!" Her hands shot forward instinctively, her fingers splayed wide. The boulder trembled, then shimmered, its solid form turning gelatinous. Krugen's snarl twisted into confusion as the stone melted, flowing over his arms and shoulders like molten wax, encasing him in a cocoon of solidifying rock.

"Please-!" Nymira gasped, every muscle in her body straining as she bent the stone to her will. Sweat trickled down her temple as her vision blurred. The effort was monumental, and her strength was waning.

Her amber eyes scanned the battlefield, desperate for a solution. War had transformed Tinmaal into a living nightmare. Werebears clashed with Werelions, their roars shaking the very ground. Werecrows darted through the sky, raining down arrows and bullets. Smoke clouded the air, and blood soaked the earth.

"What made them so... angry?" Nymira whispered through gritted teeth, her arms trembling as she maintained her hold on the stone encasing Krugen

Maar. Sweat beaded on her brow, her breath coming in short, shallow bursts. “Is this really the legacy of Farmire? I had no idea…”

A voice, quiet but steady, cut through the chaos. “The Werelions were never the most significant.”

Nymira barely registered Korva’s presence until the Wereraven appeared beside her, moving like a shadow, her crimson eyes sharp yet unreadable. “They were always on the fringes, always the outsiders,” she continued, her voice laced with something between disdain and understanding. “Farmire never saw them as equals—just brutes, tools of war when convenient, a nuisance when not. No trade, no diplomacy- no hope.”

Nymira’s arms shook as she adjusted her stance, her focus locked on the cracking stone trapping Krugen Maar. “So this is how they prove themselves? By killing? By conquering? Giving in to mere rumores?”

Korva exhaled, a dry, humorless chuckle escaping her beak. “They don’t care about proving anything. They just want to matter. They’ve spent their existence being pushed around like an annoying pest, so they’ll burn the world down if it means being remembered.”

Nymira’s breath hitched, her exhaustion pressing down on her. She thought of the libraries in Terramechus, the way Farmire’s history was recorded in cold, detached analysis. She could picture the entries now: “Werelion society: hierarchical, aggressive, technologically stagnant.” Neat. Clinical.

Dismissive. Her own people had reduced an entire civilization to a footnote, then wondered why the Werebeasts hated them.

She thought of the carvings in the corridors—the loving detail, the pride in every chiseled line. She thought of the lioness in bronze armor, the craftsmanship of the throne room door, the puzzle that had guarded the Codex. These weren't savages. They were a people who had been backed into a corner and told they didn't matter. And Krugen Maar had offered them the one thing no one else had: a reason to believe they did.

They never considered what it meant to be forgotten, to be ignored, to be told your kind held no place in the world's future.

"But that's not hope," she said, her voice barely above a whisper.

Korva tilted her head slightly, watching Nymira with an expression that wasn't quite pity, but close. "No," she admitted. "But it's all they have."

"Anyway, no time for philosophy, Nymira," Korva said briskly, her tone cutting through the weight of Nymira's thoughts. She reached into her pouch and placed the red Mantle Sphere beside her. "Here."

Nymira's arms trembled as she struggled to maintain her hold on Krugen, sweat trailing down her temple. She blinked at the Mantle Sphere, her mind sluggish from exhaustion. "Wait, how did you—?"

"I'm good at what I do." Korva smirked, but her usual arrogance was tinged with urgency. "You two were keeping Krugen busy. Made slipping in and out

easy."

Nymira exhaled sharply, trying to suppress the wave of dizziness creeping in. "You never left, did you?"

Korva shrugged. "Not with all those valuables lying around." She tossed a handful of gold coins next to the Mantle Sphere. "Bend these into an amulet."

Nymira's fingers twitched, her entire body screaming for rest. "An amulet?" she repeated, her voice hoarse. "Why? Aldric can't use magic. Ans I can't control it."

Korva crouched beside her, eyes darting to the cracking stone that held Krugen. "Aldric's a gambling man, right?"

Nymira's heart pounded as the pieces clicked. "You think the Pale Weaver's spell… is the Tombstone water?"

Korva exhaled sharply. "It's a theory. Oxren allegedly spent time with the Pale Weaver, making deals. Then the Tombstone Order appears? Right after his death? Maybe the spell isn't a chant or a scroll—but the Tombstone water itself."

Nymira's breath hitched. "If you're wrong—"

"I don't know what'll happen to him if he changes." Korva's voice wavered, just for a second. "But I know what happens if we don't try."

Nymira clenched her teeth, her arms trembling violently as Krugen's stone prison groaned. Cracks webbed across its surface, deepening. She was losing her grip. "He'll die."

Korva met her gaze. No words, just understanding.

"You have to be fast," Nymira warned, her voice unsteady. "As soon as I move, he'll break free."

Korva gave a sharp nod and bolted toward Aldric, a streak of black feathers against the chaos. She was nearly to his motionless body when she caught movement in the smoke—Zareek, the Spelltracer.

The Drakai's expression was unreadable, his light-blue eyes watching her with something close to disappointment. He wasn't preparing an attack. He wasn't even drawing a weapon.

Korva's steps faltered, her body shifting into a defensive stance on instinct. Her daggers gleamed in the dim light, but Zareek didn't react. Instead, he lifted his gaze to the sky and let out a quiet sigh. Then he turned, stepping into the brush and disappearing away from the war and chaos.

Korva's steps faltered, her body shifting into a defensive stance on instinct. Her daggers gleamed in the dim light, but Zareek didn't react. His expression held no malice—only a weariness that seemed to reach far beyond this battlefield. She recognized it. The look of someone who had picked the wrong side and knew it, but had been in too deep to leave. Until now.

His scaled hands moved in a single, deliberate sign—she didn't know Drakai sign language, but the meaning was clear enough. He was done.

Zareek turned and walked into the brush, his tail dragging behind him. No dramatic exit. No final

strike. Just a quiet departure from a war that was never his.

Korva hesitated for only a moment before snapping her attention back to Aldric.

She dropped to her knees beside him, shaking his limp form. “Come on, Aldric,” she muttered. “You’re a betting man, right? So let’s bet on this.”

With one swift motion, Korva unwrapped the vial of Tombstone ritual water and pressed it to Aldric’s lips. The thick, dark liquid flowed down his throat, the vial emptying in seconds.

The moment it was done, the cracks in Krugen’s stone prison deepened, sharp fractures spiderwebbing across its surface.

Nymira’s entire body trembled with the effort to hold it together. “I… I can’t—hold—”

Korva turned sharply, her crimson eyes flicking between Nymira’s shaking form and the weakening stone. “Then Just focus on the amulet—I’ll keep him busy!”

Nymira had no choice. She released her grip, diverting every last ounce of her strength into bending the gold and Mantle Sphere into a makeshift necklace.

The instant her focus broke, the stone exploded outward in a violent blast, shards tearing through the air like shrapnel.

A deafening roar followed, primal and enraged. Krugen emerged from the destruction, his golden eyes burning with fury.

Korva barely had time to react before he was on her. He moved impossibly fast for something his size, his claws tearing through the space she had occupied a moment before. She twisted, barely dodging his first strike, but his speed was relentless. A massive, clawed foot caught her side, the force sending her tumbling violently across the courtyard.

Krugen barely spared her a glance before shifting his attention. His gaze locked onto Aldric's unmoving body.

With a growl, he grabbed Aldric by the throat, hauling him into the air like a ragdoll. "Pathetic." He hurled him across the courtyard, his limp body skidding to a stop near Nymira.

Nymira gasped, hands shaking as she finished shaping the amulet. Without thinking, she tossed it toward Aldric, hoping he would wake up, hoping that Korva's gamble would work.

But she barely had time to see where it landed before something else caught her eye.

The Codex.

It lay a few feet away, half-buried in the dirt from the skirmish before.

There it is.

She bolted toward it, scooping it up in both hands. But the moment she turned—Krugen was already there.

Her heart seized in her chest. Too late.

Desperate, she thrust her hands downward, bending a stone barrier between them.

It didn't matter.

With a single swipe, Krugen shattered the wall like it was made of glass, the force of the impact sending Nymira flying.

Pain exploded through her body as she crashed into the ground, tumbling across the dirt and landing in a heap near the treeline with the Codex but a few feet away.

She tried to move, but her limbs wouldn't obey. Her chest rose and fell in shallow, ragged breaths. Every muscle in her body screamed in protest.

Distantly, she heard the heavy thud of Krugen's footsteps.

Slow. Measured. Certain.

She barely had the strength to lift her head, her vision swimming.

Krugen loomed over her, his massive frame blocking out the sky and canopy.

"No more games. No more tricks. No more magic."

He raised his claws, sharp and gleaming in the firelight.

"You die here, Spriggan."

Nymira exhaled, her fingers twitching weakly in the dirt. She couldn't fight anymore.

She had nothing left.

Her vision blurred.

And then—

A sound.

Low at first. Then rising.

A deep, unnatural screech split through the battlefield, sharp and otherworldly, like something

vast and ancient dragging its claws across a cosmic surface.

Krugen hesitated.

Then—

A flash of white.

Krugen turned just in time to see it.

In a void, Aldric stood in ankle-deep water, his head bowed. Four ghostly green pillars of fire flickered around him, their eerie glow reflecting off the rippling surface. The vast void stretched endlessly, silent and hollow.

He let out a slow breath. "Sorry, guys... Maybe Nymira's got another trick up her sleeve."

A deep, booming voice shattered the silence. "Giving up already?"

Aldric's head snapped up. A towering figure emerged from the fire, its form shifting between flame and shadow. Even with the flickering embers obscuring its features, Aldric could make out a sharp, chiseled jaw, a powerful stance, and a gaze that burned straight through him.

The figure didn't wait for a response. A campfire roared into existence between them, followed by two large logs made of the same ghostly fire. The figure trudged over and sat, resting its forearms on its knees.

Aldric eyed the setup warily. "Wha-."

The figure gestured to the empty log. "Sit."

Aldric hesitated, then huffed. "If this is some kind of afterlife orientation, I'd rather just skip it." Still, he sat, glancing around the void as if expecting

something to make sense. "And just who the hell are you?"

"You aint dead Wolf," the figure said instead, its voice low and unreadable.

Aldric frowned. "Could have fooled me."

"But. You drank the Tombstone water without swearing the oath. Without taking the creed. Not good."

Aldric scoffed, leaning back on his hands. "Yeah? Well, it wasn't a choice. Blame Nymira, Korva, and a bad bet."

"Your friends?"

Aldric shrugged. "Nah. Just business."

"So you'll leave them to die, then?"

That made Aldric stiffen.

His fingers curled slightly against his knee, his usual smirk faltering for just a heartbeat. "Excuse me? Did I not try hard enough for you? The fact of the matter is I did try. I lost."

The figure let out a low chuckle, shaking its head. "You drank the water, wolf."

Aldric exhaled sharply. "Oh, the damn water. The Pale Weaver's water. The rumored spell, the mystery elixir—yeah, I've heard it all." He shook his head. "Didn't work, so let's just cut to the part where you tell me what happens next."

The figure leaned forward slightly, its flames pulsing. "What's the problem, wolf? Afraid?"

Aldric shot him a glare. "Oh for the love of- It's like talking to a wall."

With a brief pause the figure's tone shifted, growing serious.

"You know what I'm talking about."

Aldric clenched his jaw. He looked away, eyes fixed on the dark water beneath him.

After a long pause, he muttered, "I've never been a fan of changing."

The figure studied him for a moment before asking, "Why?"

Aldric let out a humorless chuckle. "You ever been to Wererune? It's got everything. Cities, entertainment, food that doesn't taste like dirt—crazy gadgets, magic, all of it. I had a place near Vaulhold. It was... nice." He exhaled. "Even got to see a few Tombstones in action once. But one day a bunch of farmers were being swarmed by Hollowborn. So I thought to myself that the Tombstone looks all scary with their black scars and glowing green eyes, But people love them for taking care of the Hollowborn, so maybe the folks won't think much about a Werewolf. So I changed. Full transformation, right there in the open. Tore through the Hollowborn, saved every last farmer." His voice went flat. "And then I turned around to face the people I'd just saved, and the look on their faces... It wasn't gratitude. It was the same fear they'd had for the Hollowborn."

He stared at the dark water, his reflection rippling.

"Mothers pulling children behind them. Men reaching for pitchforks. One of them actually said it—'We don't need another monster.'" He let out a

breath that was almost a laugh. "I'd just saved their lives, and they looked at me like I was worse than what I'd killed."

The flames around the figure flickered.

"And then they cast you out," the figure said.

Aldric's smile was tight. "Not exactly a parade. Word spread. The local council gave me a choice—leave quietly or be driven out publicly. I left." He looked down at his hands. "Haven't fully changed since. Figured if even saving people's lives wasn't enough to make them see me as anything but a monster, then maybe they were right."

"And now you're afraid it'll happen again."

Aldric swallowed hard. His voice dropped. "Not just with Nymira and Korva. With everyone. Every person I've ever met since that day. Every job I've taken, every town I've passed through—I keep people at arm's length because the moment they find out what I really am, they'll look at me the same way those farmers did." He clenched his fists. "I'd rather be the cocky, annoying guy who never takes anything seriously than the monster who saved your life and got punished for it."

The void was silent for a long moment. The green pillars of fire flickered.

"That's why you call everyone 'Twig' and crack jokes when people try to get close," the figure said. It wasn't a question.

Aldric said nothing. His jaw worked, but no words came.

The figure stood abruptly, laughing.

Aldric shot him a glare. "I tell you I'm afraid, and you laugh? Doesn't exactly lift my spirits."

The figure stepped forward, placing a firm, burning hand on Aldric's shoulder.

"Here's a secret, wolf." His voice dropped to a low, almost reverent whisper. "The Werewolves were always destined for Wererune. To live together with the humans. Never to be cast out." He paused. "And still owed a gift from the Pale Weaver for their sacrifice."

He lifted his head, cracking a grin of disbelief. "And after all these years, all these lost ages... the beast to drink the water was still a wolf. Not a lion. Not a bear. Not a crow. But you."

He laughed again, shaking his head. "Maybe the Pale Weaver really can read the future."

Aldric frowned. "Wait—you know her? Who—"

The figure squeezed his shoulder, silencing him. "You can be afraid. But you cannot be a coward."

Aldric's breath hitched.

"Taking action—even when you are scared—is what it takes to save someone."

Aldric hesitated, the words sinking in.

Then he met the figure's burning gaze.

"...But—"

The figure grinned. "Aldric. Shut up."

A sharp clap landed on Aldric's back, sending a surge of warmth rushing through him.

"Go save your damn friends."

Aldric felt it—power surging, his body burning, the void cracking around him.

With one last glance at the figure, he gave a slow, steady nod.

"Right."

A blinding pillar of light split the sky then pierced through the battlefield. A new presence stood at its center, casting an elongated shadow across the war-torn ground.

Krugen Maar's breath hitched. His golden eyes widened, a flicker of awe breaking through his usual iron composure. "The Werejackal..." he whispered.

For the briefest moment, the battlefield stilled. Every Werelion, every warrior—whether friend or foe—stared in silent astonishment. The ancient myths had spoken of this moment, but none had ever seen it. Until now.

Aldric, now reborn, loomed beneath the moon's glow. He was taller than before—not just in his werewolf form, but beyond it. His sleek, obsidian-black form rippled with newfound strength, muscles corded beneath skin so dark it shimmered like polished stone. A jagged mane of golden fur trailed down his back, and his claws were longer, sharper—curved like ancient blades. His body was leaner but infinitely more deadly, every line of him built for a purpose that went beyond mere combat.

His glowing amber eyes burned with something primal, something ancient. And behind those eyes, for the first time in his life, Aldric felt no fear of what he had become.

The Werelions nearest to him backed away instinctively. Even the Werebears paused, their

primal senses recognizing something in Aldric's new form that predated all of them—a power from an age when the beasts had ruled alongside gods.

Slowly, he bent down and picked up the Mantle amulet, the red gemstone still humming with untapped power. The moment it clasped around his neck, a surge of magic crackled through him, twisting with the rage still coursing through his veins. His body tensed, adjusting, creaking and groaning under the combined strain of the transformation and the new magic coursing through him.

The world came back into motion.

Aldric's ears flicked toward the sound of approaching footsteps. He whipped his head toward Krugen Maar, his lips pulling back to reveal elongated, gleaming fangs.

Krugen extended an arm, gesturing toward the Werelions frozen in place. "What are you waiting for? Kill him!"

A Werelion warrior lunged—then staggered back. In the blink of an eye, Aldric had moved, his claws slicing clean through the lion's chest before his body even hit the ground. The red aura flared, wrapping around him like living fire, making him a blur as he tore through the ranks.

One by one, they fell—slashed, gutted, ripped apart with brutal efficiency.

"Kill anything that isn't a crow or a bear—NOW!" barked a sharp voice from the chaos. The regal, battle-worn Wereraven queen stood high atop the back of a massive Werebear, her rifle raised as she

gave the command.

A second wave of chaos erupted—this time, with every faction united by a single, primal instinct: kill the thing before it kills everything.

The abomination lurched forward, its snake-like lower body coiling around a stone pillar and crushing it to rubble. Its rat-like claws swept through a cluster of Werelion warriors, sending them scattering like leaves. A Werebear charged at its flank, war-hammer raised, and struck with enough force to crack bone—but the creature barely noticed. Its tail whipped around, catching the bear across the chest and launching him into a wall.

The Wereraven queen fired three precise shots into the creature's face. It recoiled, screeching, but the wounds sealed almost instantly—dark energy knitting the flesh back together like a living wound.

"Aim for the joints!" the queen shouted, reloading with practiced speed. "It can't heal what it can't hold together!"

Steel clashed, gunfire echoed, and the acrid scent of smoke filled the air as blades and claws met in furious combat. Arrows soared, bullets ricocheted off stone, and the battlefield became a hellscape of blood and fire.

Through the chaos, Korva turned, her eyes locking onto Nymira’s barely conscious form. “Nymira! Do something!”

Nymira blinked groggily, her hands fumbling in the dirt. Her fingers brushed against something solid—the Codex.

It had cracked. Thin, glowing tendrils of distorted energy leaked from its surface, bending the air around it. Her mind, sluggish and battered, barely registered what she was seeing. The way the energy curled, the way it seemed drawn to—

Her eyes darted to a nearby snake, lifeless on the ground, its body bloated, its last meal still visible in its swollen belly.

A bitter laugh escaped her lips. “How ironic…”

She reached out, bending the energy like she would bend stone. The reaction was instant.

A pulse of warped magic exploded outward, sending her and Krugen Maar flying in opposite directions.

The ground trembled.

From the glowing mass of raw, shifting power, something massive took shape. First, twisted limbs. Then, a grotesque blend of fur and scales. A hulking, fifty-foot nightmare of a beast—a twisted fusion of rodent and serpent. The front half was undeniably rat-like, with gnarled claws and glowing red eyes, but its lower body was the thick, coiling form of a snake. It exhaled in a guttural, hollow screech that sent shivers through even the most hardened warriors.

Silence fell across the battlefield—the kind of silence that comes when every living creature realizes, at the same instant, that something far worse than war has arrived.

The abomination's glowing red eyes swept across the courtyard, and everywhere its gaze fell, the stone cracked and the air warped. It opened its mouth—a

gaping maw lined with rows of jagged, mismatched teeth—and let out a screech that rattled armor, shattered lanterns, and sent Werelion warriors stumbling backward with their ears flattened.

Nymira stared in horror at what she'd created. The Codex's energy had been volatile, unpredictable—she'd bent it instinctively, desperately, without understanding what she was shaping. And the result was this nightmare given flesh.

Krugen, regaining his footing, stared at the monstrous abomination. For one brief moment, something flickered across his face—not fear, but recognition. He had sought the power of the Codex. He had coveted dark matter, ascension, godhood. And this is what that power looked like when it was unleashed without control.

His awe was gone. Only fury remained.

Without hesitation, he roared, “LIONS! TO ME!”

The Werelions, already battered, already struggling, turned toward their chieftain’s command. And they obeyed.

With a renewed battle cry, they charged.

Not just them—every beast, every fighter, crows, bears, lions, all of them, surged toward the unnatural horror before them, their alliances forgotten in the face of something beyond comprehension.

Tinmaal had devolved into madness.

Korva gritted her teeth, pushing herself up from where she had landed. Through the chaos, her gaze locked onto Aldric. “Get Nymira and the Codex out of

here!" she shouted, her voice sharp despite the pain.

Aldric's jackal ears flicked toward her, his breath ragged with adrenaline and fury. For a brief moment, he hesitated, every muscle coiled, every instinct screaming at him to stay, to fight, to rip Krugen Maar apart.

Then he moved.

He tore through the battlefield, cutting down Werelions with brutal efficiency, his form a blur of black fur and flashing claws. When he reached Korva, he stopped just long enough to meet her eyes—his glowing gaze filled with something unspoken, something worried.

"Go!" Korva snapped, gesturing toward Nymira's motionless form. "I'll be fine, Aldric—but she won't. Get her out of here!"

A beat of hesitation. Then a sharp nod.

Aldric turned and surged forward, his massive Werejackal form tearing through the battlefield. Warriors parted before him, some out of fear, others out of instinct. The red aura from the Mantle amulet trailed behind him like living fire.

When he reached Nymira, she was barely conscious, her fingers still twitching from the bending that had nearly killed her. In a single motion, he scooped her up with one arm, cradling her against his chest. His free hand shot out, snatching up the Codex. His eyes flickered over its surface, noting the rough, hastily patched cracks—Nymira's work.

Despite everything, he grinned.

Then he turned toward the thick trees and the safety of the Deep Woods.

“WOLF!”

Aldric stopped, his claws digging into the dirt. He didn’t turn around.

Krugen Maar, standing tall amidst the raging battle, his chest heaving, his golden eyes burning, his fur covered in blood, pointed a clawed finger toward him.

“This is no victory for you,” he snarled. “I have seen the power of the Jackal. And now, I know how close I am to taking it for myself. The Pale Weaver no longer matters.”

His grin widened, madness dripping from every word. “This is only the beginning of my reign. I will ascend. And when I do, Howl Valley and Wererune will fall.”

Aldric didn’t answer. He simply glanced over his shoulder, locking eyes with Krugen one last time.

Then, he ran.

Deeper and deeper into the woods, away from the chaos, away from the carnage—toward the unknown.

The trees closed in around him like a corridor, ancient trunks blurring past as he ran faster than he'd ever moved. The Mantle amulet burned against his chest, its power intertwining with the Tombstone water still coursing through his veins. He could feel the forest like he'd never felt it before—every root, every branch, every heartbeat of every creature hiding in the underbrush. The Deep Woods had always been alive, but now he could sense it.

Behind him, Tinmaal burned. The orange glow painted the canopy in the distance, and the roars of battle faded to distant thunder. And over it all, carrying across the smoke-filled night with the clarity of a death sentence, came Krugen Maar's laughter—rich, triumphant, and utterly unbroken.

The Werelion king had lost the Codex. He had lost the battle. But he had gained something far more dangerous: knowledge. He had seen a Werebeast ascend. He had seen it was possible. And he would stop at nothing to claim that power for himself.

Chapter 10: The Pale Weaver

Aldric tore through the underbrush, his massive Werejackal form weaving between the ancient trees of the Deep Woods. He didn't know where he was going—only that it had to be far from Tinmaal. From Krugen Maar. From the blood and fire he left behind.

Nymira hung carefully from his jaws, unconscious but alive. The Codex of Thorns was stuffed into her satchel, bouncing against his side as he sprinted on all fours, his breath coming in ragged huffs. His muscles burned, his body screaming for rest, but he pushed forward.

Behind him, the sounds of war faded—the roars, the clashing steel, the shriek of the abomination he'd left behind. He wondered if Korva had made it out. He wondered if any of them had. The Wereraven queen and her Werebear allies had been fierce, but that creature—that thing Nymira had accidentally created from the Codex's leaking energy—was something else entirely. Something that didn't belong in this world.

His new body moved differently than his old werewolf form. Faster. Smoother. The Mantle amulet pulsed against his chest, its magic intertwining with whatever the Tombstone water had done to him. He could feel things he'd never felt before—the hum of the earth beneath his claws, the pulse of energy in the trees, the faint vibrations of living things in the darkness around him. It was overwhelming and

intoxicating and terrifying all at once.

Then—a glint of silver through the canopy. A clearing.

He slowed, his claws digging into the damp earth as he padded into the open. The moon bathed the glade in an unnatural glow, but something was wrong. The grass and leaves were colorless, as if drained of life. The air felt heavier, the silence too perfect. The world here was untouched by time.

Aldric carefully placed Nymira down. He glanced at the sky and let loose a howl—long, deep, and primal. It wasn't just a warning to the shadows. It was something he'd never allowed himself before: a declaration. I am here. I am not hiding. I am not afraid.

The howl faded, and darkness swallowed him whole.

Nymira stirred, blinking blearily at the dim glow of a small campfire. Her body ached in ways she didn't know were possible—not just her muscles, but deeper, as though her bones themselves had been wrung out. A strange sensation lingered in her limbs, a phantom vibration from the sheer volume of bending she'd done. She had pushed herself past every limit she'd known, and her body was letting her know.

She pushed herself upright, wincing, and took in her surroundings. The clearing was eerily still, the trees bordering it ancient and twisted in ways that suggested great age even by Deep Woods standards. The fire crackled lazily, its embers drifting upward

like dying stars. The air here smelled different—not the loamy, animal musk of Farmire, but something cleaner, almost sterile, as if the clearing existed outside the normal rules of the forest.

A thin blanket had been draped over her—one she didn't recognize. Someone had tended to her wounds, too; she could feel the faint sting of cleaned cuts on her arms and the careful binding of cloth around a bruise on her ribs.

Across from her, Aldric lay unmoving, back in his human form, covered with a similar blanket and using a makeshift pillow of folded cloth. His breathing was steady but shallow, and even in sleep, his face held none of its usual cockiness. He looked exhausted. He looked young.

Then, a voice.

"Ah, there you are."

Nymira's head snapped up. From the shadows, a figure emerged.

Tall. Slender. Otherworldly.

At first glance, she resembled an Aetherdren, but there was something… wrong. Her bark-like skin wasn't the rich green of Terramechus but ashen gray. Her black hair fell in loose strands, untouched by the natural curls of her kin. But it was her eyes that struck Nymira the hardest—cold, luminous violet, like distant stars.

Her voice was smooth and haunting, carrying an elegance both arcane and unnatural. "You're quite the resilient one."

Nymira’s breath hitched. "An Aetherdren?" she whispered, her pulse quickening. Then, realizing the impossibility of it, her expression darkened. "No… A Hollowborn?"

The woman’s lips barely moved, but the hint of a smirk tugged at them. "I am Aetherdren, child. Not Hollowborn."

Nymira stiffened. A being like this could only be one thing.

"The Pale Weaver."

The woman dipped her head slightly, as if amused. "Ah, so the rumors still live." A pause, then a quiet chuckle, more in thought than humor. "I should be more careful. That Spelltracer nearly led Krugen right to me."

Nymira’s mind snapped into focus. "Zareek?" she asked, still trying to catch up with everything. "What does he have to do with you?"

The Pale Weaver’s unreadable eyes studied her. "We all play a part in destiny, child. But finding the path… that is the challenge."

Nymira frowned, her head still foggy. "That doesn't answer my question."

"You wouldn’t be satisfied with the answer," the Pale Weaver said smoothly. Then, as if deciding to humor her, she added, "I told Zareek to unite the Vesper Drakai with the Werelions years ago. He was placed in an… unfortunate position."

Nymira’s mind reeled. The Vesper Drakai—the nomadic faction that had been in constant conflict with the ruling Shahara Drakai. She had read about

them, how they had no true home, wandering the Drylands like ghosts.

She narrowed her eyes. "You told him?"

The Pale Weaver ignored her skepticism. "Krugen offered him a deal—help in overthrowing the Shahara, in return for the Vesper's loyalty."

Nymira scoffed. "Loyalty? That's not loyalty. That's desperation."

A slow, knowing smile crept across the Pale Weaver's face. "Yes."

Nymira shook her head. "And Zareek's 'gift' to Krugen Maar?"

The Pale Weaver's glowing violet eyes darkened slightly. "His ability."

"Spell tracing?" Nymira frowned. "I mean, it's useful, but Aldric was right—it's not some world-ending skill. There are other Spellcasters who can track magic."

The Pale Weaver's smile widened, just a fraction. "Oh, child. So intelligent, yet so naïve." She exhaled, almost wistfully. "There has only ever been one other who could do what Zareek does."

Nymira's stomach dropped. "...You."

The Pale Weaver only nodded.

Nymira swallowed hard, trying to push away the unease creeping into her bones. "Still, I don't see how that connects to all of this."

The Pale Weaver lowered herself onto the ground, sitting gracefully as if the earth itself bent to accommodate her. "The ability to track spells is not learned. It is understood. Like gravity. We know it

exists. We use it. But if someone truly understood it—" her violet eyes gleamed— "what else could they do?"

Nymira hesitated, feeling like she was teetering on the edge of something vast and terrifying. "So... you can break spells down to their casters. Find them anywhere. That makes you a powerful assassin."

The Pale Weaver's expression barely shifted, but her silence was answer enough.

Then she tilted her head slightly, her voice dropping to a whisper. "What if I could track myself?"

Nymira's eyes widened. "...You could teleport to yourself."

A slow nod.

A weight settled on Nymira's chest. The Pale Weaver wasn't just moving through space—she was moving through time.

Nymira opened her mouth, but the words didn't come.

The Pale Weaver smiled, though there was something almost... pitying in it. "It is not as glamorous as one might think." Her voice, once smooth and teasing, carried a weariness now. "It takes work. Patience. Trial and error. And most of all—time."

Nymira wasn't sure if she was still breathing.

The Pale Weaver watched her carefully. "But even I need help from time to time."

Nymira's mind snapped back to the present. "A deal?" she asked, cautious. "You want the Codex?"

For the first time, the Pale Weaver actually looked surprised.

"The Codex?" she murmured.

Nymira reached into her satchel and pulled it out, the thorned sphere glinting in the moonlight. She held it out in one hand.

The Pale Weaver stared at it for a moment, then—

She laughed.

Soft at first, then deeper, as if genuinely amused.

"Oh, child," she said, shaking her head. "Consider it a gift."

Nymira blinked, stunned.

A pause. Then she leaned back, rubbing her temple. "Today has been… a lot."

The Pale Weaver gave a knowing smirk. "Oh, yes. Especially with Aldric's Ascension."

Nymira stiffened. "You saw that?"

The Pale Weaver didn't answer. Instead, she simply smiled. Like she had seen it many, many times before.

A heavy silence settled between them. The campfire crackled, sending sparks drifting upward into the colorless canopy.

Nymira's mind raced through everything she'd learned—the Codex, the Tombstone water, Zareek's gift, the Werejackal, and now this. A being who could move through time itself. The implications were staggering, and for the first time since leaving Terramechus, she felt not fear but wonder. The universe was so much larger than the research papers and controlled experiments she'd spent her life

mastering.

"Why did you give Krugen the means to find you?" Nymira asked quietly. "Zareek's ability. You must have known he'd use it."

The Pale Weaver's violet eyes softened—not with warmth, exactly, but with something ancient and tired. "Sometimes, child, you must let dangerous people believe they are in control. Krugen needed to feel powerful. Zareek needed to feel useful. And I needed them both exactly where they ended up tonight."

Nymira stared at her. "You planned all of this?"

The Pale Weaver's smile was neither confirmation nor denial. "I have lived long enough to know that plans are fragile things. But I have also lived long enough to know which way the wind blows before the storm arrives."

She glanced at Aldric's sleeping form, and something almost tender crossed her ancient features. "He will need guidance. The Werejackal is not just a form—it is a bridge between worlds. Between magic and matter. Between what the Werebeasts are and what they were always meant to become."

"And what were they meant to become?"

The Pale Weaver rose, brushing the colorless grass from her robes. "That, child, is not my story to tell."

Finally, the Pale Weaver exhaled, stretching her arms. "But back to business—this old tree still needs rest."

Nymira shook off the last of her daze. "...Can you get us to Howl Valley?"

The Pale Weaver gave a soft chuckle. "Absolutely, child."

Nymira glanced at Aldric, then back at the Pale Weaver.

"...Alright."

The Pale Weaver raised a single hand. The air crackled, the moonlight twisted, and the world shifted.

Then, the clearing was empty.

Epilogue: Howl Valley

The first thing Nymira noticed was the silence—not the oppressive, predatory silence of Farmire, but something gentler. The kind of quiet that came from a place that felt safe.

She opened her eyes to towering pines, their trunks so massive they seemed like guardians over a hidden valley. Morning mist clung to the ground, and somewhere nearby, water tumbled over stone. The air smelled of pine sap and wet earth and something faintly sweet—woodsmoke from a cooking fire.

She was lying on a bedroll that wasn't hers, inside a wooden structure with a sloped roof and carved wolf sigils over the doorway. Warm light filtered through the cracks.

Aldric sat on a low bench across the room, his elbows on his knees, staring at his hands. He was back in human form—or whatever counted as human for him now. The same silver hair, the same scars, the same leather armor. But something was different. His posture. The way the air around him seemed to hum, barely perceptible, like a held breath.

The Mantle amulet hung from his neck, its red gemstone dim but steady.

Nymira pushed herself upright, wincing. "How long was I out?"

"Through the night," Aldric said without looking up. "Ermok's people took us in. Didn't ask too many questions." He paused. "Yet."

"And the Codex?"

"In your satchel. Right where you left it."

Nymira looked down. The satchel sat beside the bedroll, the thorned sphere visible through the open flap. She ran her fingers over its surface—still warm, still humming faintly. The cracks were hairline now, barely visible. Her repair work had held.

Silence settled between them. Not uncomfortable. Just heavy.

"So," Nymira said carefully. "The Werejackal."

Aldric let out a slow breath. "Yeah."

"How do you feel?"

He turned his hands over, studying his palms. "Like I've been plugged into something I don't have the manual for." He flexed his fingers, and for the briefest moment, his nails darkened, sharpened—then returned to normal. He caught her watching and dropped his hands. "It's fine. I've got it under control."

"Do you?"

He met her gaze. For once, there was no smirk, no deflection. "I don't know."

Nymira held his look for a long moment. Then she nodded slowly. "We'll figure it out."

Aldric blinked, caught off guard. Then the corner of his mouth twitched—not the cocky grin, but something quieter. Something real.

"Yeah," he said. "I guess we will."

Outside, the sounds of Howl Valley drifted in—the murmur of voices, the bark of a distant wolf, the creak of wooden bridges swaying between the pines. A place

that felt like it had been waiting for them.

Nymira swung her legs off the bedroll and stood, testing her weight. Her body protested, but held. She slung her satchel over her shoulder—the Codex, the tools, the spent artifact casings. Everything she'd carried into Farmire and back.

She walked to the doorway and paused, looking out over the valley. The mist was thinning, revealing carved homes nestled among the trees, their roofs covered in green moss. Wooden walkways connected the homes to a central longhouse, and beyond that, a training ground where young Werewolves were already sparring in the early light. The village was smaller than Terramechus, simpler, rougher—but it had something Terramechus didn't. It felt like a home, not a laboratory.

Somewhere, children laughed. The sound was so ordinary, so impossible after everything they'd been through, that Nymira felt her throat tighten.

"Aldric."

"Yeah?"

"Thank you."

He stood slowly, joining her at the door. "For what?"

She didn't answer right away. Instead, she watched the valley wake up—the smoke rising from cookfires, the Werewolves moving through their morning routines, the massive tree at the center with its carved wolf's head watching over everything.

"For not being a coward," she said.

Aldric was quiet for a moment. Then he nudged her shoulder with his.

"Don't get used to it, Twig."

She almost smiled.

They stood together in the doorway as the sun broke through the canopy, golden light spilling across Howl Valley. Behind them, the Deep Woods stretched endlessly—and somewhere beyond, Farmire burned with the promise of war.

But that was tomorrow's problem.

Today, they were alive.